BMS-01 · WORLD & INDIAN HISTORY · MID-TERM

History Midsem: Exam Essentials

All the key points from the readings and PPTs, explained in simple language with examples, diagrams and ready model answers. Side details are left out; a grey "Skip" note marks them. Sessions 1–4 and 6–11 (Session 5 is not in the syllabus).

How to use this guide (read in 1 minute)

Each session has the same 5 parts

1. **In one line**: the whole session in one sentence. If you remember nothing else, remember this.
2. **Picture it**: a diagram or map.
3. **All key points**: each **keyword** explained in simple words, with an **e.g.** example
4. **Names & dates**: only the ones worth writing in an answer.
5. **Write it like this**: a ready model answer you can adapt.

The exam (Lecture 16)

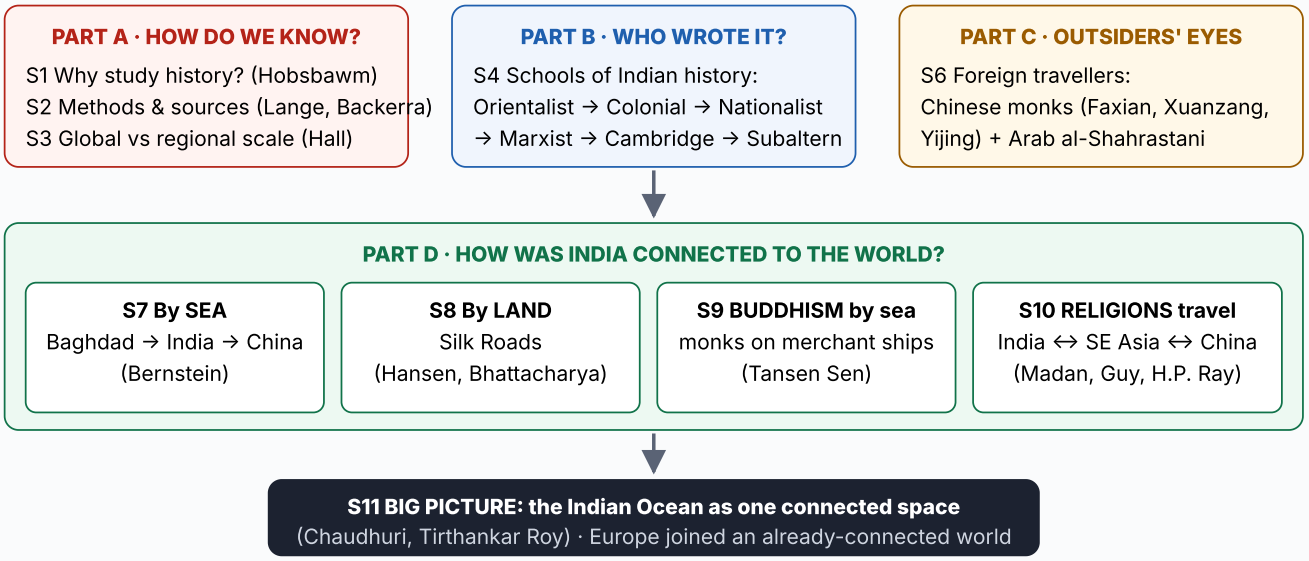
- **Part A**: 10 MCQs × ½ mark = **5**
- **Part B**: answer 3 of 5 short questions × 10 = **30**
- **Part C**: 1 essay out of 2–3 × 15 = **15**
- Total **50 marks**, 2 hours, closed book.

The professor wants: paragraphs (not bullet points), the **name of the scholar**, at least one **example** (a place, person or date), and a short **critical point** ("but…").

THE 4-STEP FORMULA FOR EVERY ANSWER

1. Say what the scholar argues in one line ("Hobsbawm argues that…"). **2. Explain 2–3 points**, each with an example. **3. Add one "but"** (a limitation or criticism). **4. End with one line** linking to the big course idea (e.g. "this shows that India was connected long before Europe arrived").

The whole course on one page



Read top to bottom: first how history is done, then who wrote India's history, then how India was linked to Asia.

FIVE IDEAS THAT APPEAR AGAIN AND AGAIN (USE THEM IN ANY ESSAY)

1. **People use the past for present needs** (Hobsbawm).
   e.g. Nationalists praised ancient India; China's Belt and Road uses the old "Silk Road" name.
2. **Every source has a point of view, so check it against other sources.**
   e.g. al-Shahrastani never visited India, so trust al-Biruni more.
3. **The scale you choose changes the story.**
   e.g. Vasco da Gama looks different from Indian, Indian Ocean and world viewpoints.
4. **Asia was connected long before Europeans came.**
   e.g. Arab, Gujarati and Tamil merchants traded from Africa to China.
5. **Religion travelled with traders and changed on the way.**
   e.g. Buddhist monks sailed on merchant ships to China.

SESSION 1

Why Study History?

E.J. Hobsbawm, "The Social Function of the Past: Some Questions", *Past & Present* (1972) · Hobsbawm, *On History* (1997), ch. 3 (covered through the PPT)

IN ONE LINE

Every society uses its past. The real question is *how*: as a pattern to copy, a model to choose from, or a process that explains how we got here. The past is often selected, reshaped or even invented for present needs.

Who is Hobsbawm? A famous British **Marxist** historian who wrote on class, nationalism, capitalism, revolution and empire. His 1972 essay started as a conference paper in 1970. It mostly **raises questions** rather than giving final answers ("It is easier to formulate questions than answers").

1. The core argument MUST KNOW

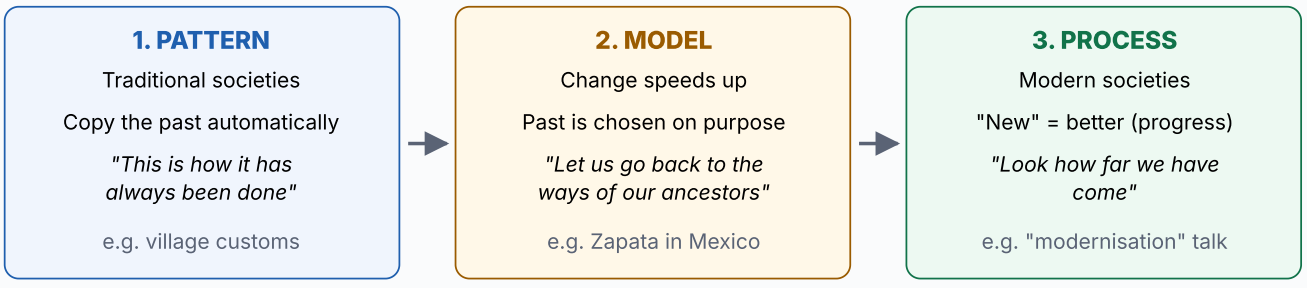
"THE PAST IS A PERMANENT DIMENSION OF THE HUMAN CONSCIOUSNESS"

In simple words: no person or society can escape its past.

- Everyone is aware of a past because we all live with **people older than us** (parents, grandparents).
- **Every society has a past**. Even brand-new colonies are made of people from old societies.
- To **belong** to a community means placing yourself in relation to its past, even if you reject it.
- So the question is not *whether* societies have a past, but **how they use it**: as authority, a moral guide, a political weapon, an identity, or a way to understand change.
- The historian's job is to study this **"sense of the past"** and how it changes. The past is not just inherited; it is **organised and used**.

"We swim in the past as fish do in water, and cannot escape from it."

2. Picture it: three ways a society uses its past



The faster a society changes, the more it moves from left to right.

3. Past as PATTERN: traditional societies MUST KNOW

- For most of history, the past was the **pattern** for the present. Each generation tried to **copy** the one before and felt it had failed if it did not.

- Old customs, ancestors' authority, sacred texts and old law were treated as **rules**. History here is not a story of progress but a **storehouse of precedents** ("what was done before").
- In societies without writing, **law = custom**, and old documents gain almost **spiritual authority**.

e.g. A village claims its common lands because "we have always used them", or even cites an old colonial court decision as proof. The past works like a charter (licence) for the present.

How does a traditional society change? (key point)

TRADITIONAL SOCIETIES ARE NOT FROZEN

Hobsbawm calls the idea that traditional society never changes "**a myth of vulgar social science**". Change does happen, but it is **absorbed in ways that do not openly challenge tradition**.

Four ways change sneaks in

1. **Gradually**: so slowly that nobody notices.
2. **Hidden (concealed)**: done without being admitted.
3. **Renamed**: "new wine in old bottles".

   e.g. Nomads who traded camels began trading **lorries** and saw it as the same old business.
4. **Stretching the framework**: old myths and rituals are stretched to fit the new thing.

Three mechanisms for innovation without breaking tradition

1. The official "past" is only a **selection** of everything remembered, so there are **gaps** (interstices) where new things can enter unnoticed.
2. **Technology** is the most flexible area.

   e.g. Tradition-bound peasants happily took up horses or new weapons without feeling they were breaking with the past.
3. Really big innovations are made acceptable by **disguising them as a return to a forgotten past**, or by a **higher authority** such as a religious revelation or a prophet.

Tradition is strong not because it blocks all change, but because it can absorb change while seeming to stay the same.

What if change is too fast?

This kind of tradition needs **slow** change. If change is too fast, tradition survives only by:

- **Isolation**:

  e.g. the **Amish** in the USA cut themselves off.
- Accepting one huge forced step **at great human cost**:

  e.g. the forced conversion of **Mexican Indians** to Catholicism after the Spanish conquest.

"Tradition" itself changes

What "has always been done" changes over time without people noticing.

e.g. What was "traditional" for **Bulgarian peasants in 1850** was very different from earlier centuries, yet they still felt traditional.

Such a past fits ideas of **cycles** or **decline**, but **not** the idea of continuous **progress**.

4. Past as MODEL: when change speeds up MUST KNOW

- When change becomes too fast, the past "must cease to be the **pattern** of the present, and can at best become the **model** for it".
- **Key difference:** a pattern is copied **automatically**; a model is **consciously chosen, selected and adapted**.
- The past becomes a **"mask for innovation"**: calls to "go back" actually produce something new.
- **Big insight:** when a society starts **loudly demanding restoration**, continuity has **already broken**. The past has moved from lived tradition to a conscious reference point.

Restoration, and the problems with Zapata (key point)

Hobsbawm is **sceptical** of the word "restoration", because you can never simply bring back the past. It always involves **selection, rebuilding or reinventing**.

EXAMPLE: ZAPATA AND THE PEASANTS OF MORELOS (MEXICO)

The peasants led by **Zapata** wanted to restore their society to what it had been **about 40 years earlier**, before the rule of **Porfirio Díaz** took their lands. **Why it could not work as a real restoration (3 problems):**

1. **Memory problem:** they had to **reconstruct things nobody could remember exactly** (e.g. the precise boundaries of the old common lands), so they ended up imagining "**what ought to have been**".
2. **It could not be cut out:** the change they hated was not "**a bullet lodged in the flesh**" that could be surgically removed. It was part of a **much wider change** in society.
3. **Bigger effects than intended:** the movement released forces far larger than its aim. The peasants became a **revolutionary power**, and the attempt to turn the clock back became a **social revolution** that helped create "**a historically unprecedented new Mexico**".

(Hobsbawm uses John Womack's biography of Zapata, 1969.) **Lesson:** trying to go back to the past can produce something completely new.

Effective restoration

Tries to bring back the **actual** old practices and institutions.

e.g. Calls to restore "old-time religion" (everyone in church); 19th-century British radicals wanting to bring back small peasant farmers.

vs

Symbolic restoration

Brings back only the **feeling, symbol or meaning**, not the real old world (often because what people want back, like "greatness" or "freedom", is too vague).

e.g. Rebuilding **Warsaw's** bombed old town after WWII; pulling down the **Stalin monument in Prague**; Churchill insisting the bombed Parliament be rebuilt exactly as before.

5. The invented past: artefact or "fabrication" MUST KNOW

- If the past people appeal to is **very remote**, it becomes just a **language for present wishes**: an artefact or, "in less flattering terms, a **fabrication**".
- Such a past is only weakly linked to real history but is **politically useful**: it can be arranged into a story that justifies the present. Even recent, made-up traditions can be very powerful.

Examples of remote / invented pasts

- English radicals' "free Anglo-Saxons before the **Norman Yoke**" and "**Merrie England**".
- "**Charlemagne**" used as a symbol for European unity since Napoleon, though nobody wants 9th-century Europe back.
- The new country "**Ghana**" took the name of an old empire from a different place.
- **Zionism**'s "return" to pre-diaspora Israel in practice denied 2,000 years of actual Jewish history.

Nationalism: the clearest case

Renan: nations "**get their history wrong**". Their goals are new, but they describe them as historic (especially **claims to territory**), and they revive old things on purpose.

e.g. Welsh "druids"; **Hebrew** revived as a spoken language; the Nazis' medieval-style castles. Hobsbawm: "History is the most easily worked **raw material**" for making nations. (Indian nationalists' "golden age", S4.)

Contrast: in truly traditional societies, restoring a remote past is meant **literally**.

e.g. Peruvian peasants (to the 1920s) rose up to restore the **Inca Empire**; for them the Incas were "yesterday".

6. Past as PROCESS: modern societies MUST KNOW

- People **reject** the past only when innovation is seen as **unavoidable and good**, i.e. as "**progress**". In modern culture "new" and "revolutionary" (as in adverts) mean "**better**".
- People accept **technological** change far more easily than **social or moral** change (family, sex, religion).

  e.g. "Has there ever been a serious Luddism against **bicycles** or transistor radios?" Popular religion accepted cheap printed holy pictures but fought changes to holy **texts**.
- The past now works as a **process**: the story of **development and evolution** that explains how the present came to be.

  e.g. Bagehot's *Physics and Politics* (1872); modern "modernisation" theory.
- Even **conservatives** start thinking historically ("even conservative thought becomes historicist").
- **Paradox:** "the **more change** dominates social life, the **more important history** becomes" as a tool for understanding it.

THE PROBLEM OF THE FUTURE

Even people designing a totally new future look for examples in the past.

e.g. Socialists pointed to "primitive communism" as a precedent.

But history shows **tendencies**, not exact outcomes.

e.g. Marx was sure socialism would replace capitalism but said almost nothing about what socialism would look like.

So "**History ceases to be of use at the very moment when we need it most**." We then dip into the past for useful **precedents**.

e.g. What happened to the poor displaced by 19th-century railways helps us think about 20th-century motorways; medieval "student power" helps us think about modern universities.

7. Genealogy: searching for ancestors MUST KNOW

Genealogy means more than family trees: groups place themselves in a **line of ancestors** to gain continuity, prestige, legitimacy and comfort for their insecurity. New nations, new elites and revolutionary movements all want **heroic ancestors**, even symbolic ones.

e.g. Revolutionaries claiming **Spartacus**, Thomas More and Winstanley as ancestors (although Marxist theory says Roman slave revolts could not lead to communism); schoolbooks teaching Boadicea, King Alfred and **Joan of Arc**; newly rich people buying aristocratic pedigrees; Stalin-era claims that Russians invented everything.

8. Chronology and historical thinking (key point) MUST KNOW

For modern historians, dates matter

Chronology = putting events in the right **order, with dates and duration**. Modern history assumes history is about **change in one direction**, so order matters.

Anachronism (putting something in the wrong time) is an "**alarm signal**" for historians.

e.g. Macbeth acted in modern dress shocks us today, but did not shock audiences in Shakespeare's time.

In traditional uses, dates don't matter

When the past is a pattern, model or moral lesson, the **moral or symbolic meaning** of a story matters more than **when** it happened.

e.g. Romans and Moors marching together in Spanish Easter processions; only pedants care whether Horatius came before Mucius Scaevola; Masada and the Maccabees matter to modern Israelis for their meaning, not their dates.

- When real chronology is brought into a sacred or mythical past (e.g. scholarly dating of Homer or the Bible), it **disturbs** society and is a sign of transformation.
- Yet dates still matter for practical purposes (law, administration, ritual).

e.g. A **lawyer** looks for a precedent to use **now**; a **historian** cares about how **different** past circumstances were.

History	Memory	Myth
Careful reconstruction using dates, order and evidence	What a group **chooses** to remember	A story that carries **meaning** (moral, symbolic)

9. *On History* (1997), ch. 3: what can history tell us about today? MUST KNOW

Link between the two texts: the 1972 essay asks how **societies** live with the past; *On History* asks how **historians** use the past to **explain** the present. You cannot understand the present without its history. History is a tool of **demystification** (removing false beliefs).

History CAN

- Show the **roots** of present institutions
- Show how nations, identities and traditions were **built**
- Reveal that many "new" things are part of **longer developments**
- Separate **real breaks** from recycled rhetoric

vs

History CANNOT

- Give mechanical **lessons**
- **Predict** exactly what happens next
- Replace political **judgement**
- Give a ready-made **programme** for action

Discussion questions (lecture): Why do societies appeal to the past most loudly in crises? (Because continuity has already broken.) Is nationalism possible without selective history? (Renan: no.) Does modern society break from the past or just reorganise it? (It reorganises it: past as process, genealogies.)

Hobsbawm · *Past & Present*, 1972 | Zapata (Morelos, Mexico) | Warsaw = symbolic restoration | "myth of vulgar social science" | Renan: nations get history wrong | Bagehot 1872

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. Explain Hobsbawm's idea of the past as pattern, model and process.

Hobsbawm (1972) argues that "the past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness": every society uses its past, but how it uses it depends on how fast it changes.

In **traditional societies** the past is a **pattern**: people copy inherited customs, and law equals custom. Yet these societies are not static (static tradition is "a myth of vulgar social science"). Change is absorbed gradually, hidden, or renamed, as when nomads treated lorries as part of their camel trade. Innovation enters through gaps in the remembered past, through technology, or disguised as a return to a forgotten past. If change is too fast, tradition survives only through isolation (the Amish) or at great cost (the forced conversion of Mexican Indians).

When change accelerates, the past becomes a **model**, consciously chosen. Loud calls for "restoration" show that continuity has already broken. Zapata's peasants tried to restore their lands of 40 years earlier, but they had to imagine what they could not remember, the change could not be cut out "like a bullet", and their movement became a revolution that created a new Mexico. Restoration may also be only **symbolic**, like rebuilding Warsaw.

In **modern societies** the past becomes a **process** of progress that explains the present; "new" means "better", and even conservatives think historically.

But the past is often selected or invented, especially by nationalism. History cannot predict the future, though it explains how the present was made.

SESSION 2

Historical Methods, Sources & Practices

Matthew Lange, *Comparative-Historical Methods* (2013), ch. 1 · Charlotte Backerra, "Source criticism for cultural history", *Rethinking History* (2024) + Lecture 2

IN ONE LINE

Historians work like detectives: they find sources, check whether they can be trusted (Backerra), interpret them, and explain why things happened, often by comparing cases (Lange).

1. What are historical methods? MUST KNOW

- Historical methods are **systematic** ways of studying the past. History is **analytical, not just descriptive**: historians explain **why** things happened, not only **what** happened.
- Steps: ask a question → find evidence → evaluate sources → compare societies → explain change → present an argument.
- **Source vs evidence:** a **source** is any trace left from the past (letter, coin, tomb, photo). It becomes **evidence** only when a historian **checks it** and uses it to answer a **specific question**. Almost anything can become a source if it helps answer a question (Backerra).

The four stages of historical method (lecture table)

Stage	Purpose	Key question	What can go wrong
1. Heuristics	Collect evidence	"What survives, and where?"	Missing evidence; mistaking a copy for the original
2. Criticism	Check if genuine and reliable	"Is it real? Is the author believable?"	Wrong author, forgery, trusting a biased witness
3. Hermeneutics	Interpret meaning	"What did the author mean, in that context?"	**Anachronism**: reading modern ideas into the past
4. Synthesis	Build the story	"How do the parts fit together?"	**Whig history**: telling the past as a straight march of progress to today (**teleology**)

Types of sources

Primary = made at the time (diaries, letters, court records, newspapers, photos, inscriptions, coins, travel accounts). **Secondary** = later analysis (scholarly books and articles). **Tertiary** = summaries (encyclopaedias, textbooks).

e.g. Xuanzang's diary is primary; a historian's book on Xuanzang is secondary; an encyclopaedia entry is tertiary.

Practice: oral history and archives

Oral history (Oral History Association): preparation → interview → preserve → give access. The key ethic is **informed consent**. **Archival research** (American Historical Association): plan → research on site → cite properly. The key ethic is **provenance** (where a document came from).

Five schools of history writing (lecture table) MUST KNOW

School	Focus and method	Main criticism
German Historicist (**Ranke**)	Events; reads **archives** and state papers critically	E.H. Carr: "naive objectivism" (thinks the historian is neutral)
Annales (Bloch, Febvre, Braudel)	**Longue durée** (long-term structures): geography, population, farming; many disciplines	Avoids politics and recent history
Marxist (Marx, E.P. Thompson)	Modes of production, **class conflict**	Too deterministic and teleological
Subaltern / postcolonial (Guha, Spivak)	Voices of peasants and the marginalised	Risk of essentialism (treating groups as fixed)
Cliometrics / digital (Fogel, North)	Statistics, big data, economics	Reduces meaning to numbers

Shared ideas and tensions: all try to use primary sources, avoid anachronism and admit bias. **Objectivity vs disclosure:** Ranke saw the historian as a neutral recorder; Hayden White said every story is shaped ("emplotted"), so today historians openly state their question, sources and framing.

2. Lange: comparative-historical analysis (CHA) MUST KNOW

LANGE'S ARGUMENT

CHA has produced some of the most famous social science (Adam Smith, Tocqueville, Marx, Weber, Barrington Moore, Tilly, Skocpol). From 1986 to 2010 CHA books won **a quarter of the American Sociological Association's best-book awards**, yet there was **no textbook** explaining the method. Lange fills that gap. CHA is special because it **combines different methods** and **balances the particular and the general**. Its big topic is **social change**: state building, nationalism, capitalism, industrialisation, revolutions, democratisation, empire, globalisation.

Within-case methods (the "historical")

Look **deep inside one case** over time:

- **Causal narrative**: a detective-style account of causes
- **Process tracing**: following the chain that links A to B
- **Pattern matching**: testing theories against one case's evidence

e.g. How exactly did the French monarchy collapse?

+

Comparative methods (the "comparative")

Compare **several cases** to find similarities, differences and causes. Types: narrative, Millian, Boolean, statistical. CHA mostly uses **small-N** (a few cases).

e.g. Compare the French, Russian and Chinese revolutions.

The 4 defining elements of CHA

1. **Within-case** methods
2. **Comparative** methods
3. **Social-scientific** outlook: believes real causes can be found (postmodern views that deny this are "anti-methodological")
4. **Big units**: states, classes, economies, religions. Tilly: "big structures, large processes, huge comparisons"

What is NOT CHA (and why)

- **Said's *Orientalism***: compares and narrates, but is postmodern (denies social-science insight)
- **Acemoglu et al.** on colonial legacies: only statistics, no within-case study
- **Tilly's *Contentious French***: deep study of France but no comparison

They are excellent works; each just lacks one element.

Key vocabulary (in simple words)

Methodology	The whole set of rules for gaining knowledge. Michael Mann: really **one** methodology in 8 steps (problem → variables → hypotheses → sample → measure → data → test → conclude).
Method	A technique for analysing data.
Nomothetic	Explanation by **general laws** for many cases (from Greek *nomos*, law).
Ideographic	Explanation of **one unique case**. Tilly: this is not "a bungled attempt at generalization".
Positivism	The belief that the scientific method is the best route to knowledge (extreme form: social laws exist).
Verstehen	German, "understanding" (Weber): aim to understand **meaning**, not to find laws.
Epistemology	The study of what we can know and how.

Lange compares the main methods

Method	What it does	Strength	Weakness
Statistical	Patterns across many cases	Tests theories, generalises	Correlation ≠ causation; weak on mechanisms
Experimental	Gives a "treatment" to subjects	Strongest proof of cause	Impossible for revolutions; ethical limits
Ethnographic	Observation and interviews (anthropology)	Rich detail on culture and motives	Can't study the past; people change behaviour when watched
Historical	Finds and narrates evidence on one time and place	Insight into complex past events	Hard to generalise; depends on what survives
CHA	Comparison + within-case; uses secondary sources	**Biggest toolkit**; bridges unique and general	Historians say it simplifies; positivists say it isn't general enough

Two famous examples

Reinhard Bendix, *Kings or People* (1978): compared how 6 countries (England, France, Germany, Japan, Russia, China) moved from kings to popular rule; **each path was unique** (ideographic).

Theda Skocpol, *States and Social Revolutions* (1979): revolutions happen when the **state breaks down AND peasants can rebel**, but only for non-colonial agrarian states in a certain period (a balance of general and particular).

Why combining methods matters

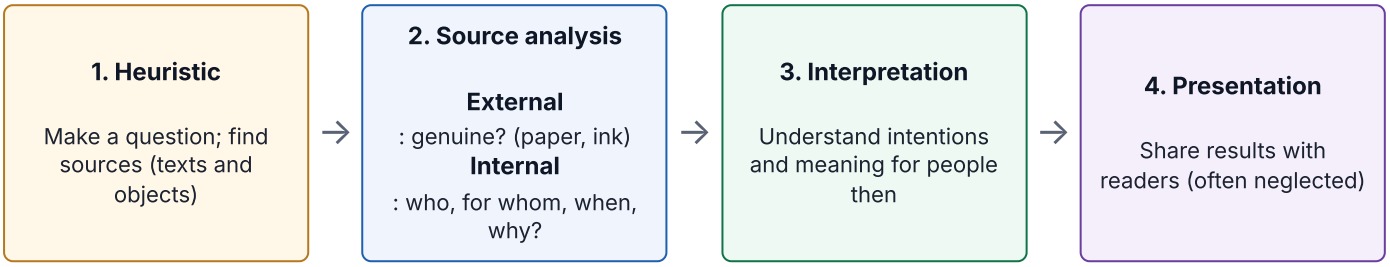
Comparison pushes you towards **general** explanations; deep study of one case pushes you towards the **particular**. Using both stops you from over-generalising ("all revolutions are caused by X") and from treating every case as totally unique. That is why CHA sits **in the middle**, and is criticised from both sides.

3. Backerra: source criticism for cultural history MUST KNOW

BACKERRA'S ARGUMENT

Source criticism has been the historian's basic method since the 1800s and has barely changed in 150 years. Today's **cultural historians** ask new questions and use new materials, so they reach different interpretations, often **without reflecting** on how they are changing the method. The basic **analysis** of a source stays the same; what changes is the **heuristic** (the questions and sources) and the **interpretation**. The last step, **presentation**, remains "largely unreflected" (not thought about enough).

Humanism	"*Ad fontes*" ("back to the sources")
Early 1800s	**Tübingen School**: critical reading of the Bible; Niebuhr
1830s	**Ranke** makes source-reading courses standard
1868	**Droysen**, *Historik*: the 4 steps
1889	**Bernheim**'s big textbook spreads the method
Today	Digital tools: online archives, text mining, **Transkribus** (handwriting reading)



Droysen: the steps go "back and forth", not strictly in order.

Droysen's 4 kinds of interpretation

1. **Pragmatic**: cause and effect
2. **Conditions**: place, time, resources
3. **Psychological**: actions come from character
4. **Ideas**: events express the ideas of an age

4 forms of presentation

1. **Investigative**: follows the question, shows choices
2. **Narrative**: tells a story
3. **Didactic**: "learn from history"
4. **Discursive**: argues with other historians (most common today)

Backerra's case study: early modern diplomatic letters (examples to use)

Old political historians used diplomats' letters only to find out "**who said what to whom, when**". Cultural historians also ask about **rank, ceremony, symbols, space, language and emotions**, i.e. "**what did it mean?**"

Layout and labels

Wider blank margins = higher-ranking reader. Letters were folded and sealed in special ways. "**Secret**" letters held key information (sometimes in code); "**private**" meant only the king and ministers could read it, not "personal".

Ceremony and language

Ceremony filled **half** of a diplomat's instructions (who visits whom first showed rank). The emperor wrote to George II in **Italian**, the king replied in **French**, and in **German** when writing as a vassal. Latin titles were changed to downgrade "majesty".

Networks, space, weather, emotion

Newspapers show the envoy **Kinsky** fencing and hosting balls in London (social networks missing from official letters). British envoys lived in a house **outside Vienna's walls**, which let them hold Protestant worship. An envoy writing "I never knew what **Cold** was" likely meant the **frozen negotiations**. Displays of emotion are read as **performances**.

Cultural history widens the sources

Not only government archives but rituals, symbols, emotions, objects, newspapers, personal letters and everyday life. **Peter Burke**: cultural history is a **way of looking**, not a separate field. Backerra asks historians to openly say "**I**" or "**we**" instead of pretending to be neutral.

4. Lange + Backerra together MUST KNOW

Lange	Backerra
Explains historical **change**	Explains how **evidence** is judged
Focus on **causes**	Focus on **source criticism**
Uses **comparison**, builds theories	Uses **interpretation**, builds reliable evidence
"What does this evidence **explain**?"	"Can we **trust** this evidence?"

Ask questions → find sources → check them (Backerra) → compare cases (Lange) → interpret → explain.

"History is both an art of interpretation and a science of evidence."

Droysen 1868 · **Ranke** 1830s · **Lange**: CHA · **Backerra**: cultural history · Tilly · Skocpol · Bendix · Mann's 8 steps

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. "Lange shows how historians explain; Backerra shows how they know." Discuss.

Historical method is both a science of evidence and an art of interpretation, and the two readings cover each side.

Lange explains how historians build **causal explanations** through comparative-historical analysis. CHA has four elements: within-case methods (causal narrative, process tracing), comparison across cases, a social-scientific belief that causes can be found, and big units like states and classes. Skocpol, for example, found that revolutions need both state breakdown and peasant power. CHA balances unique (ideographic) and general (nomothetic) explanation. This is why works such as Said's *Orientalism* do not count as CHA.

Backerra explains how historians decide whether evidence can be **trusted**, through source criticism (Droysen's heuristic, analysis, interpretation, presentation). Cultural historians use the same method with new questions: in diplomatic letters, wide margins showed rank, the choice of language showed status, and ceremony filled half the instructions.

But comparison can over-generalise, and presentation is still neglected. Together they make the full workflow: find → check → compare → explain.

SESSION 3

Global and Regional Histories: Scale, Perspective, Context

Thomas D. Hall (ed.), *Comparing Globalizations* (2018), ch. 1 (Hall) & ch. 8 (on "place", via the lecture) + Lecture 3

IN ONE LINE

Global history asks how places are connected; regional history asks how a place works inside. Historical understanding is strongest when we ask both questions together, because the scale you choose changes the story.

1. Why study history at many levels? MUST KNOW

The problem

- Events don't happen at only one level.
- Local life is shaped by bigger systems.
- Big systems are built from regional links.
- National history alone is often **too narrow**.

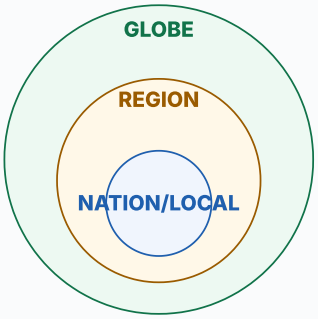
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The principle

- History happens at **many levels**.
- Scale shapes the **questions** and the **answers**.
- No single scale is always enough.
- History doesn't fit neatly inside today's **nation-states**.

2. Picture it: zooming in and out

Global history
• connections, trade, movement
• risk: too abstract
e.g. the world economy



Regional history
• depth, local life, diversity
• risk: too isolated
e.g. Bengal, Gujarat

Lecture diagram idea: regional depth → connections (movement, exchange, conflict, power) → global patterns.

	Global history	Regional history
Studies	Connections across borders between distant places	A specific historical space (can be inside a country, across borders, or a big macro-region)
Focus	Movement, exchange, big processes	Local dynamics, inner diversity
Contribution	Challenges isolated national stories (e.g. Wallerstein)	Recovers hidden voices; **tests** big claims
Key question	**How are places linked?**	**How did a place work inside?**
Danger	Too **abstract**	Too **isolated**

3. Wallerstein's world-system MUST KNOW

What it says

Immanuel Wallerstein (*The Modern World-System*, 1974): since the 16th century the world economy has been **one system** with a **division of labour**:

- **Core**: rich, skilled, capital-heavy production
- **Semi-periphery**: in between
- **Periphery**: raw materials, cheap labour

e.g. Europe as the core; colonies as the periphery.

"A world-system is not the system of the world"

It means "a system that **is a world**" (a self-contained world), which can be **smaller than the whole globe**. It is the **largest unit** of social change: empires, states, societies and families exist **inside** it. The parts shape the whole, and the whole limits the parts.

(S8 link: Wallerstein put South Asia in the "semi-periphery"; Washbrook disagreed, and Bayly and Ludden called it Eurocentric.)

4. Hall: "Comparing Globalizations" MUST KNOW

HALL'S MAIN CLAIMS

1. **There is not one globalization but MULTIPLE globalizations.**
2. Globalizing processes have **long, deep histories**; they became "truly global" only in the last century or so. Today's globalization has new features, but they didn't appear from nowhere: "**How can one tell what is new if one does not already know what is old?**"
3. Different **world-systems** arose at different times (many since the **Neolithic**, about 12,000 years ago).
4. **Comparison** is more useful than one straight-line story, and what is worth comparing depends on **your purpose**.

Andre Gunder Frank (with Gills, 1993)

ONE world system growing for **5,000 years** (written "world system", no hyphen).

vs

Chase-Dunn & Hall (1997)

MANY world-systems of different kinds since the Neolithic (written "world-systems", with a hyphen).

Hall jokes the debate looks like "nit-picking about a hyphen", but the hyphen marks a real difference. **Janet Abu-Lughod** (*Before European Hegemony*, 1989) showed a linked world system from Europe to China in 1250–1350, **before** Europe dominated.

Hall's lessons about comparison

Apples and oranges

It's fine to compare apples and oranges **if you are discussing fruit**; add baseballs if you are discussing round objects. The **purpose** decides what is comparable.

Context matters

Narrow views give detail but miss the big picture.

e.g. A cartoon of a young stock-market whiz asking "you mean they can go **down**?": narrow experience limits understanding.

Bigger contexts can show that "constants" are actually **slow-changing variables**.

Move between levels

Some local processes can't be seen from far away, and very slow changes (like climate change) can be invisible in short spans of data. Know when to treat something as fixed and when as changing.

Turning points and comparison across time

Moments when a boundary is crossed and everything changes, e.g. the **rise of the state**. If you study only recent decades, you can't even ask such questions.

e.g. Julian Go compares the British (19th c.) and American (20th c.) empires at the same "stage" and finds America is **not exceptional**.

THREE DEBATES IN HALL'S VOLUME (SHORT)

(1) **Afroeurasia was linked early** (Abu-Lughod, against Wallerstein). Jared Diamond: Eurasia's **east–west axis** helped plants and animals spread. (2) Similar stages of social evolution happened **in parallel** in the Old and New Worlds (Sanderson). (3) **Small luxury trade** (silk, gems) could have **big effects** at both ends of a network (Turchin & Hall), so luxury goods can matter as much as bulk goods. Many authors study systems "**from the bottom up**", from the periphery.

5. Hall ch. 8: nation, region, globe MUST KNOW

- A historical "place" can be seen at three levels: **nation, region, globe**. Each shows different patterns, so historians must **move across scales**.
- **Modern national borders mislead us about the past.** "India", "China" or "Bangladesh" did not exist in their modern form earlier.

e.g. Bengal's history spans today's India and Bangladesh (S8).

Why India is the perfect test case

- Always had **many regions** inside it
- Old ties to **Asia, Africa and the Indian Ocean**
- Can't be reduced to **one national story**
- Shows **inner diversity + global connection**

The Indian Ocean: where regional meets global

A **coherent macro-region** with its own logic, and also part of wider Afro-Eurasian networks, linking East Africa, Arabia, India and Southeast Asia through trade, migration, religion and empire (S7, S11).

Example to memorise: Vasco da Gama (1498) at 3 scales

Scale	How his arrival at Calicut looks
National	The beginning of Europeans in India, which later led to colonial rule
Regional	A **new player** in an ocean already full of Gujarati, Arab, Mapilla and Chetti merchants (a **Gujarati pilot** even guided him)
Global	A shift in Eurasian trade: the **Cape route** as an alternative to the Red Sea, Gulf and Venetian routes

Lesson: the Portuguese **changed existing networks** but did not **create** connection. Europe entered an **already-connected** world (the central claim of S7 and S11).

Wallerstein 1974 | **Hall**: multiple globalizations | **Frank**: one 5,000-year system | **Chase-Dunn & Hall**: many | Abu-Lughod 1250–1350

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. Why should global and regional histories be read together? Use India as an example.

Global history studies how places are **connected** (trade, migration, empire); regional history studies how a place **works internally**. Each alone is weak: global history can become too abstract, regional history too isolated.

Hall argues that there were **multiple globalizations** with long histories, not one modern one: "how can one tell what is new if one does not know what is old?" Wallerstein's world-system ("a system that is a world") links a core and a periphery, while Frank sees one 5,000-year system and Chase-Dunn and Hall see many. Such big models need regional detail to test them, and the right comparison depends on the purpose.

India shows why both are needed. It contains many regions, yet it was linked to Africa, Arabia and China through the Indian Ocean, which is both a region and a global arena. Vasco da Gama's arrival in 1498 looks like the start of colonialism at the national scale, but regionally he was only a new player, guided by a Gujarati pilot.

Since modern borders mislead us about the past, good history moves across scales and asks both "how was it connected?" and "how did it work inside?"

SESSION 4

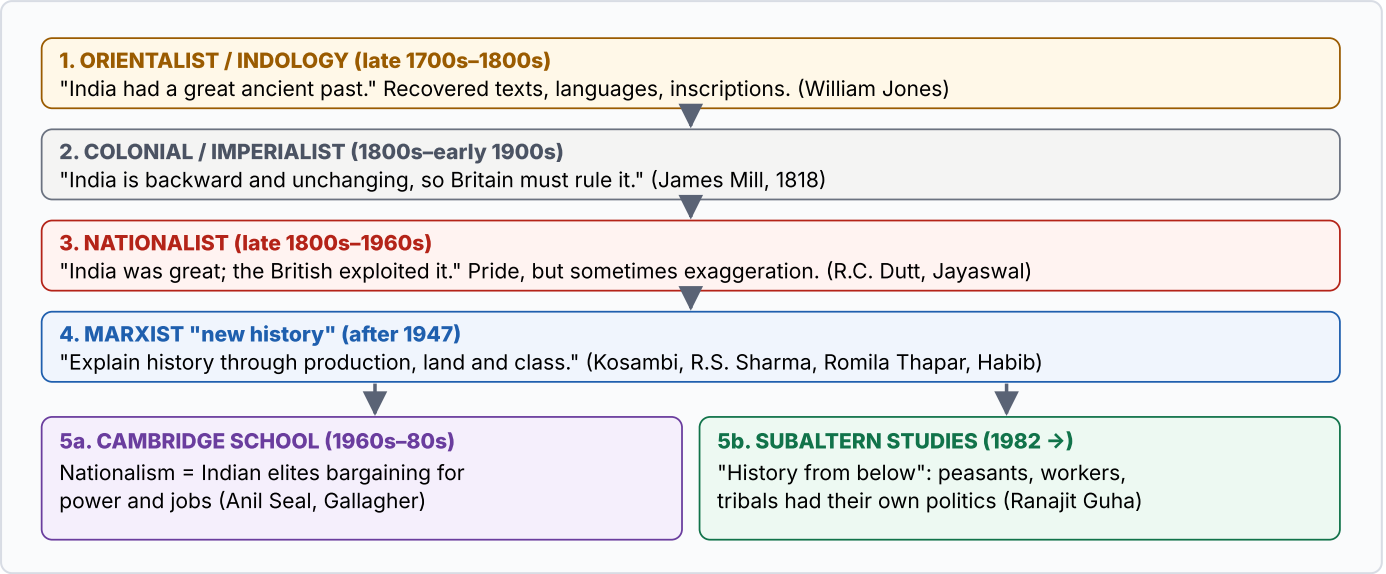
Indian Schools of Historical Thought

E. Sreedharan, *A Textbook of Historiography*, chs. 14–16 + Lecture 4 (adds Said and the Cambridge School).
Very likely essay topic; the professor's model essay is from here.

IN ONE LINE

Indian history has been written by different groups, each reacting to the one before: Orientalists recovered ancient India, colonial writers called it backward, nationalists defended it, Marxists studied economy and class, the Cambridge School studied elite politics, and Subaltern historians studied ordinary people.

Picture it: the chain of schools (learn this order)



1. The starting problem: ancient India "without history"? MUST KNOW

- For **medieval** India there were Muslim court chronicles, so the British knew it fairly well. But **ancient** India seemed to have **no proper history books**, so it had to be rebuilt from **indirect sources**: literature, inscriptions, coins, monuments, sculpture.
- Sreedharan: the traditional Hindu view did not treat everyday history as "useful knowledge"; there was a vague, exaggerated sense of age.

  e.g. In 1808 the pundit Mrtyunjay Sharma wrote a Bengali history with kings ruling for **lakhs of years**.
- Early British writers: **Robert Orme** (1764, military history; mocked Hindu gods), **Francis Gladwin** (Mughal history), **William Robertson** (collected Greek and Roman mentions of India). Ancient India stayed "a land of marvel and mystery".

Exam point: Indian history had to be "**built from fragments**". This is the problem Indology tried to solve.

2. Orientalists / Indology MUST KNOW

Indology = the systematic study of India's history, languages, literature, religions and culture.

Why did the British study India? (5 influences)

1. **Enlightenment**: differences between peoples come from culture, not nature, which led to tolerance and curiosity (Voltaire admired India and China).
2. **Romanticism**: fascination with ancient, mysterious places.
3. A new **scientific, critical** way of handling sources.
4. **Comparative** scholarship.
5. **Ruling needs**: officials had to know Indian languages, law and culture.

> **e.g.** Governor-General **Warren Hastings** was the great patron: he learned Persian and loved the Gita.

Early British Indologists

- **Nathaniel Halhed**: *Gentoo Laws* (1776), Bengali grammar
- **Charles Wilkins**: first direct English translation of the **Bhagavad Gita (1784)**
- **Gladwin**: abridged *Ain-i-Akbari*
- **Jonathan Duncan**: encouraged Hindu learning

Indology came from a mix of **curiosity, administrative need, patronage and imperial rule**.

William Jones (1746–1794) and the Asiatic Society

A Welsh language genius, judge of the Supreme Court in Calcutta (1783). In **January 1784** he founded the **Asiatic Society of Bengal** (modelled on the Royal Society, London), which made Indian research **organised and collaborative**. He translated ***Shakuntala* (1789)** (which thrilled Goethe and the German Romantics), the *Gita Govinda* and *Manusmriti*.

Jones's discovery	What it was	Why it mattered
Indo-European languages (1786)	Sanskrit is a "cousin" of Greek, Latin, Persian and English, all from one lost mother language. **e.g.** Sanskrit *duhitr*, English *daughter*, German *Tochter*.	Started comparative philology (the study of language history)
The "Aryan race" (a big leap)	From a **common language** he jumped to a **common race** ("Aryans")	Later misused (see the "seamy side")
Sandrocottas = Chandragupta (1793)	Greek sources on Alexander mention King "Sandrocottas" at "Palibothra". Jones matched these to **Chandragupta Maurya** at **Pataliputra**.	Gave the first firm date, **325 BC**, the **"sheet anchor"** of Indian chronology, from which other dates are counted

After Jones: two lines of work

(1) Studying ancient texts

- **Colebrooke**: *Essay on the Vedas* (1803); pictured the Vedic age as a **golden age** (no sati, no caste, no idols)
- **Anquetil Duperron**: translated the Upanishads (via Dara Shukoh's Persian); admired by Schopenhauer
- **Burnouf**: made Buddhism known in the West
- **Max Müller**: edited the Rig Veda; *Sacred Books of the East* (50 volumes)

Problem: texts had to be dated and used carefully.

+

(2) Inscriptions, coins, archaeology

- **Epigraphy** = study of inscriptions; **numismatics** = study of coins
- **James Prinsep** (Calcutta Mint) read **Brahmi** in **1834**, turning the legendary Ashoka into a **historical** emperor. "Reading one script can open a whole historical world."
- **Alexander Cunningham**: father of Indian archaeology, head of the **ASI** (Sarnath, Sanchi, Taxila)
- Colin Mackenzie collected 8,000+ south Indian inscriptions; later **Harappa** showed civilisation existed **before** the Vedic Aryans

Achievements

- Brought **modern methods** (source criticism, philology, epigraphy, archaeology, coins) to Indian history
- Fixed a **chronology** (325 BC)
- Revealed Indian literature and philosophy to the world, a "**Renaissance in the East**"
- Irony: as India was conquered, British scholars showed it was a great civilisation

but

The "seamy side" (Sreedharan)

- The language → **race** link was false, yet "white Aryan superiority" became a **justification for British rule**
- **Aryan invasion theory**: superior Aryans conquered "inferior" Dravidians and created caste, an Aryan–Dravidian divide
- Everything good in India was credited to **European** (Aryan) origins
- **Exaggeration** (Jones: "Sanskrit more perfect than Greek"), later fuelling Indian **chauvinism**

Reading Orientalism through Edward Said (lecture) MUST KNOW

Said, *Orientalism* (1978): European scholarship on "the East" was not just study; it was part of a relationship of **power**. "The Orient" was not simply discovered; it was **constructed** by European knowledge.

3 meanings of "Orientalism"

1. An **academic field** (studying Asian languages and cultures)
2. A **style of thought** (dividing the world into "West" and "East")
3. A **discourse of power** (knowledge that helped Europe rule the East)

How knowledge helped rule

- Translating Hindu law → British courts could apply "native law"
- Learning Sanskrit and Persian → officials could govern
- Classifying castes and religions → society became "readable" for the state
- Archaeological surveys → India's past catalogued under colonial authority

THE BALANCED VERDICT (USE THIS)

The Orientalists **genuinely** helped recover ancient India, but this knowledge was produced **within colonial power**, and the same person was often scholar, judge and ruler (Jones was a judge). So the result was **double-edged**: India was revealed, but also classified and represented through European categories.

3. Colonial / imperialist history MUST KNOW

After Plassey (1757), three British groups argued over how to rule India:

Group	Who	View
Conservative / Orientalist	Hastings, Jones, Colebrooke; later Elphinstone, Munro	Respect Indian civilisation; change slowly
Evangelical	Charles Grant, missionaries	Indian society is "hideous"; cure it with **Christianity** and Western education
Utilitarian	Bentham, **James Mill**	Remake India through laws, education and strong (despotic) government

James Mill, *History of British India* (1818)

- A utilitarian who **never visited India** and knew no Indian language. He decided his conclusions **before** writing and used only **hostile** witnesses (missionaries, travellers), ignoring favourable evidence (a failure of source criticism, S2).
- He called Hindu society one of the "**rudest**" states of mind; even feudal Europe was superior; British rule was best.
- He divided history into **Hindu, Muslim and British periods** (still used!).
- **Influence:** Macaulay praised it; it was the textbook at **Haileybury College** (1805–55), where British civil servants were trained, so they arrived with "imperial dogmatism".
- **Critics:** H.H. Wilson said it destroyed sympathy between rulers and ruled; R.C. Majumdar said it "does not deserve the name" of history.

Others in this school

- **Mountstuart Elphinstone** (1841): fairer and more sympathetic; built a sound chronology from Chandragupta; laid the foundation of **cultural history** ("Tacitus of India"); yet still said Hindus lacked "veracity".
- **Elliot & Dowson** (8 volumes, 1867–77): translated Persian chronicles but attacked **Muslim** rule, so Indians would value "the mildness of our rule".
- Ideas of the age: **race superiority**, Social Darwinism, Kipling's "**White Man's Burden**" (1899), the "civilising mission".

Administrator-historians (c.1870–1940): all concluded British rule must continue

Historian	Key argument
Henry Maine	The Indian village is a frozen old Aryan institution; India is "the infancy of the human mind prolonged"; Britain brings progress
Alfred Lyall	The British conquest was quick because India was a "loose conglomeration of tribes, races and castes", not a nation
W.W. Hunter	A pioneer of economic history ("the silent millions… have found no annalist"); British rule would unite India
Vincent Smith	Standard textbooks (1904); admired the Guptas but said India only knew "despotism" and needed British rule; gave Alexander far too much space
W.H. Moreland	Economic history of Mughal India (agriculture, land revenue); called Mughal rule a legacy of loss
E.B. Havell (dissenter)	Aryans gave India village democracy, so India deserves self-rule: "No greater spiritual injury can be done to a people than to teach them to despise… their forefathers"

THE 4 ASSUMPTIONS OF IMPERIALIST HISTORY (MEMORISE)

1. **Static India**: it never changed (Mill), so Hegel placed India outside world history.
2. **Oriental despotism**: cruel kings over self-contained villages with no private land. Marx turned this into the "**Asiatic Mode of Production**".
3. **Purpose**: if India never changed, Britain could claim to be the **agent of change**, which justified its rule.
4. **Political bias**: moral judgements, focus on the British period, written for English readers.

> **e.g.** Morley told Gokhale that a fur coat needed in Canada was not needed in the Deccan (no self-rule for India).

4. Nationalist history: defending Indian civilisation MUST KNOW

Context: educated Indians wanted to become "more Indian and less English" and needed a proud history. Bankim Chandra: "**There is no Hindu history.** Who will praise our noble qualities if we do not praise them ourselves?" They reacted against Mill, Elphinstone and Smith, and against claims that Indians **borrowed everything** (e.g. that the sine in trigonometry must be Greek; Needham showed India used it from the Gupta age). R.C. Majumdar: a nationalist historian is not necessarily "a propagandist or a charlatan".

Area	What nationalists argued
Religion & society	Defended Hinduism; Dayananda: only the Vedas are true, and idols, caste and sati are later additions; caste explained as a division of labour; Vedic women had high status
Material culture	**R.C. Dutt**, *Civilization in Ancient India* (1889), moderate and scientific. Extremes: Tilak dated the Rig Veda to 4000 BC; claims of aeroplanes in the epics. **R.K. Mookerji**, *History of Indian Shipping* (1912)
Politics	Against "India is not a nation": Mookerji, *Fundamental Unity of India* (1914). Against despotism: **K.P. Jayaswal, *Hindu Polity* (1918)**, ancient republics, assemblies (sabha, samiti), even "voting"
Against British	Plassey blamed on treachery; **Savarkar** called 1857 the "Indian War of Independence"; Tarachand stressed Hindu–Muslim cultural unity

Strengths

- The **greatest stimulus** to historical research in India: scholars went to the sources
- Moved history from collecting facts to **interpretation**
- **Regional history** (Bengal, Maharashtra, the south: Nilakanta Sastri)
- Birth of **economic history**: Naoroji's **drain theory**, Dutt's *Economic History of India* (1904)
- Cultural history (Tagore, Panikkar)

but

Weaknesses

- History made to **serve present politics**. Basham: Jayaswal used sources "like a **barrister** trying to win a case"
- **Chauvinism**. Thapar: glorifying the past was "a compensation for the humiliating present"
- **Contradictions**: military glory vs non-violence; spiritual vs worldly
- Hindu-centred stories of Rajputs, Marathas and Sikhs vs Muslims fed **communalism**

Names the lecture stresses: R.G. **Bhandarkar** (careful, impartial "dry truth"), R.C. **Majumdar** (editor of the 11-volume *History and Culture of the Indian People*; "History, divorced from truth, does not help a nation"), K.P. **Jayaswal**, H.C. **Raychaudhuri** (*Political History of Ancient India*, 1923). Also Jadunath **Sarkar** (Mughals; ruthless with sources), K.M. **Panikkar** (India and the Indian Ocean), Nilakanta **Sastri** (south India, the Cholas).

5. Marxist "new history" MUST KNOW

WHAT MADE IT "NEW"

Not mainly **new evidence**, but "a **re-reading of the sources with a different set of questions**": class relations, modes of production, land and farming, surplus (who takes the extra produce), caste and economy, state formation. History became a **social science**.

D.D. Kosambi (the founder)

- History = "the presentation, in chronological order, of successive developments in the **means and relations of production**" (tools, and who controls work).
- Even without dates, we can know **how people lived**. He used archaeology, fieldwork, tribes, language and coin weights: India is full of "**living survivals**" of the past.
- **From tribe to caste**: the **plough** (spread by Brahmin settlement) broke up tribes, and caste became the new way to organise labour.
- **Buddhism and Jainism** had economic roots: new traders and landowners wanted peace; **ahimsa** saved cattle needed for ploughing.

R.S. Sharma · Romila Thapar · Irfan Habib · Bipan Chandra

- **R.S. Sharma**: *Indian Feudalism* (land grants to Brahmins and officials, decline of towns and trade after the Guptas); *Sudras in Ancient India*; *Urban Decay* (from archaeology).
- **Romila Thapar**: Ashoka's **dhamma** was a social and political policy to hold a diverse empire together; **no massive "Aryan invasion"** (small groups spread the language); *From Lineage to State*.
- **Irfan Habib**: Mughal empire's heavy land-revenue demand crushed peasants, who revolted; the empire was "its own grave-digger".
- **Bipan Chandra**: economic nationalism; attacked the Cambridge School (nationalism was a people's movement); communalism was a product of colonialism.

Why it was an advance

- From kings and battles to **society and ordinary people**
- **Interdisciplinary**: archaeology, anthropology, statistics
- Strong on **origins**: how states formed in the Ganga valley
- **Explanation**, not just narrative; processes over events
- Destroyed old myths: "static India", Oriental despotism, the "Aryan race"

but

Criticism

- Same theory, **different conclusions** (Sharma and Thapar disagreed on Buddhism and slavery)
- Weak proof (e.g. how many cattle were really sacrificed?)
- **Jargon** ("exercises in obscurity")
- Lecture: class can become a rigid "**master explanation**", ignoring culture, religion, region and ideas

6. Cambridge School vs Subaltern Studies MUST KNOW

Cambridge School (1960s–80s)

Anil Seal, John Gallagher, Gordon Johnson, C.A. Bayly. The freedom movement was mainly about **local politics, patron–client networks, elite competition, factions**, and bargaining with the British. Nationalism was the "response of the Indian elite to British stimuli".

e.g. Critics (Bipan Chandra, Guha): it ignores ideals, mass politics and real anti-colonial feeling.

vs

Subaltern Studies (Ranajit Guha, 1982)

"**Subaltern**" (from **Gramsci**) = people of lower rank (by class, caste, gender). Both colonial and nationalist histories are "**elitist**": one credits the British, the other credits Indian leaders. Neither can explain mass uprisings (1919 anti-Rowlatt, 1942 Quit India). Peasants, workers and tribals had their **own autonomous politics**; a peasant rebelled **consciously** when petitions failed.

Subaltern historian	Example study
Gyan Pandey	Peasant revolts in Awadh (1919–22)
Shahid Amin	How peasants saw **Gandhi** as a miracle-worker
Dipesh Chakrabarty	Calcutta jute-mill workers; elitism even in left unions
David Arnold · Ramachandra Guha	Hill-tribe rebellions in Andhra · forest protests in Kumaun (roots of Chipko)
Sumit Sarkar	Swadeshi stayed upper-caste; popular action in Non-Cooperation alarmed the leaders

Strengths

Gave agency to people earlier seen as "crowds, mobs or followers"; recovered neglected records; reopened settled questions.

but

Weaknesses

A loose elite/subaltern divide; fragmented topics with no big narrative ("sub-history"); risk of essentialism.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS: THE PROFESSOR'S ESSAY (15 MARKS)

Q. Was the shift from colonial and nationalist history to Marxist "new history" a major advance?

Intro: Each school of Indian history reflected the politics of its time (Hobsbawm: the past is used for present needs). Marxist history was a real advance in method and scope, but not the final word.

Colonial history: James Mill (1818), who never visited India, used hostile sources and described India as static and despotic, which justified British rule. His Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation trained Haileybury officials. Maine and Smith repeated these assumptions.

Nationalist history answered with pride: Jayaswal's ancient republics, Mookerji's "fundamental unity", and Dutt's and Naoroji's drain theory, which began economic history. **But** it often glorified a golden age "as compensation for the humiliating present" (Thapar) and fed communal history.

Marxist history asked new questions of old sources: production, land and class. Kosambi showed how the plough turned tribes into caste society; Sharma studied feudalism; Thapar saw Ashoka's dhamma as policy and rejected the Aryan invasion; Habib showed peasant revolts against Mughal revenue. It moved history from kings to society, used archaeology and destroyed colonial myths.

Limits: class could become a rigid master explanation and the jargon was heavy. The Cambridge School stressed elite bargaining, and Subaltern Studies (Guha, 1982) showed that even Marxists missed peasants' own politics.

Conclusion: a major advance in scope and method, but history keeps being rewritten from new angles.

SESSION 6

India through the Eyes of Foreign Travellers

Tansen Sen, "The Travel Records of Chinese Pilgrims Faxian, Xuanzang and Yijing" (2006) · M.S. Khan, "A Twelfth Century Arab Account of Indian Religions and Sects" (on al-Shahrastani, 1983) + Lecture 6

IN ONE LINE

Foreign travellers fill gaps where Indian records are missing, but every travel account is evidence and interpretation at once, so historians must question it and check it against other sources. Together they show India was connected, not isolated.

1. Why study foreign travellers? MUST KNOW

- Sources for India's past: **archaeology** (remains), **inscriptions** (official records in stone or metal), **coins** (rulers, dates, trade), **literary texts**, and **foreign travellers** (outsiders' accounts).
- Foreigners noticed **everyday details** (food, dress, city life) that locals took for granted and never wrote down.
- **Travel writing** = a description of a society by someone from outside, mixing first-hand experience with their own outlook: geography, economy, cities, religion, customs, trade, politics, food.

Observation — what they saw + **Memory** — often written years later + **Interpretation** — through their own worldview + **Opinion** — judgements of people and rulers = **Travel writing** — useful but biased

How to read a travel account: 6 questions MUST KNOW

Ask	Why it matters (example)
Why were they visiting?	The purpose shapes what they noticed (pilgrims looked for monasteries)
Who was the audience?	A report for a king differs from private notes (Xuanzang wrote for Emperor Taizong)
What languages did they know?	This limits what they could check (al-Biruni knew Sanskrit; al-Shahrastani did not)
What sources did they use?	Own eyes, hearsay, or older books?
What did they leave out?	Silences matter (al-Shahrastani omits the Vedas and Jainism)
What assumptions shaped them?	Beliefs colour judgements (al-Shahrastani's Islamic idea of "prophecy")

Advantages

- **Eyewitness** accounts
- Information **found nowhere else**
- **Comparisons** with their own country
- An **independent** outsider view (less tied to local politics)

but

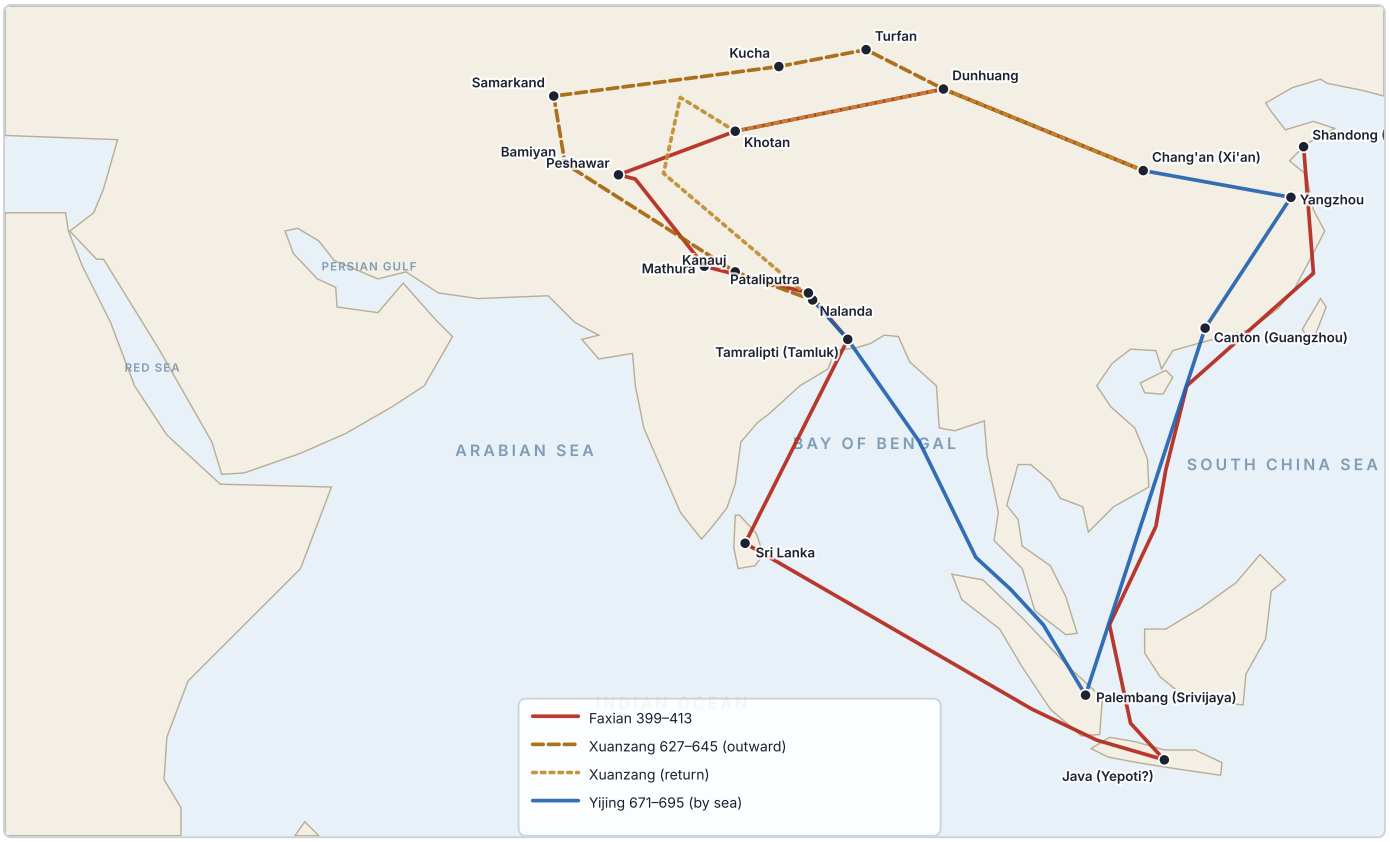
Limitations

- **Language barriers**, reliance on interpreters
- **Religious bias**
- Saw only **part** of India
- **Exaggeration**; noticed the unusual, not the typical

Traveller	When	From	Purpose
Megasthenes	4th c. BCE	Greece	Envoy to Chandragupta's court; wrote *Indica*

Faxian	399–413 CE	China	Buddhist pilgrim (Vinaya texts)
Xuanzang	627/629–645	China	Pilgrim, scholar, almost a diplomat
Yijing	671–695	China	Pilgrim by sea; monastery rules
Al-Biruni	973–1048	Central Asia	Scholar; visited India and learned Sanskrit
Al-Shahrastani	1086–1153	Persia	Scholar of religions; **never visited**

Lecture question: "Did they all come for the same reason?" No: diplomacy, pilgrimage, scholarship, curiosity (and later trade).



Routes of the three Chinese pilgrims (approximate). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

2. The Chinese pilgrims (Tansen Sen) MUST KNOW

SEN'S ARGUMENT

Buddhism's spread from India to China (from the 1st century CE) started huge **cross-cultural exchange**: monks, traders, artisans and doctors moved across Central and Southeast Asia. The pilgrims brought texts, ritual objects and detailed records. Their writings made China see India as a **sacred, even ideal land** of "**civilised**" people. That was rare praise, because Chinese writers usually called foreigners barbarians. Their records are valuable for: (1) Buddhist doctrine, rituals and monasteries; (2) social and political conditions in India; (3) how cultures saw each other; (4) the hardships of travel and the **monk–merchant** relationship.

Why did they come? To collect **scriptures**, visit places linked to the **Buddha's life**, learn Sanskrit and study with Indian teachers, then bring texts home for translation.

Faxian (left Chang'an in 399, aged over 60)

- Came for **Vinaya** texts (rules for running monasteries), which were scarce in China.
- Route: across the **Taklamakan desert** → Central Asia → Indian holy sites → **Sri Lanka** → a dangerous **sea voyage** home via Southeast Asia (sailed from **Tamralipti**, stayed 2 years in Sri Lanka).
- Recorded Buddhist legends and **relic** worship (the Buddha's bowl at Peshawar, the **tooth relic** in Sri Lanka), which spread such ceremonies to China.
- **Monks and merchants helped each other**: monks travelled with caravans and ships; traders profited from demand for ritual goods; monasteries gave traders lodging.
- One of the earliest outside accounts of **Gupta** India. His book: *A Record of the Buddhist Kingdoms*.

Xuanzang (c.600–664), "the greatest Chinese traveller"

- Unhappy with poor Chinese translations ("when words are wrong, the meaning is lost"), he wanted **original texts** and Indian teachers.
- Brought back **657 texts**; Emperor Taizong built the **Big Wild Goose Pagoda** to house them.
- Met King **Harsha** at **Kanauj** (637/638), which led to **diplomatic relations** between Harsha and Tang China. So he was a **pilgrim and a diplomat**.
- Studied at **Nalanda**; gave India the Chinese name "**Yindu**"; surveyed caste, education, cities, food and law.
- His notes help **archaeologists** today (Bamiyan, Nalanda); R.S. Sharma used his reports of decaying towns.

Yijing (635–713)

- Travelled mainly **by sea** (671–695) and studied at **Srivijaya** (Sumatra) on the way.
- Wrote about **40 daily practices** in Indian monasteries to correct Chinese "errors", and biographies of **56 Chinese monks** who went to India.
- Allowed sensible compromise.

  e.g. Indians don't use chopsticks, but the rules don't forbid them, so Chinese monks may keep them.
- Showed India within a **wider Asian Buddhist world** (links to Southeast Asia).

The "borderland complex"

Chinese monks felt China was on the **edge** ("borderland") of the Buddhist world, far from the Buddha's land.

e.g. Faxian's companion stayed in India, wishing "not to be reborn in the borderland". At Nalanda, monks asked Xuanzang why he would go back to a land where "Buddhas are never born"; he replied that China was civilised and the Dharma must spread.

The pilgrims tried to **recreate an Indian Buddhist world inside China** so others need not travel. Yijing: "a second Rajagriha in China".

What the pilgrims teach historians (lecture): Buddhist **networks** between monasteries, **universities** (Nalanda), city life, **trade routes** shared by monks and merchants, **diplomacy** between courts, and cultural interaction. "**Religion became a vehicle connecting Asia.**"

3. Arab scholars and al-Shahrastani (M.S. Khan) MUST KNOW

Why were Arabs interested in India? Trade; the spread of Islam into South Asia; scientific curiosity (Indian maths and astronomy fed the translation movement in **Baghdad**); and **comparative religion**, "one of the great

contributions of Muslim civilisation".

712	Arab conquest of **Sind** brings close Hindu–Muslim contact
771	An Indian scientist visits the Abbasid caliph in Baghdad
786–803	The **Barmakid** ministers send an envoy to report on Indian religions (preserved in Ibn al-Nadim's *Fihrist*)
11th c.	**Al-Biruni** writes critically, from Sanskrit sources
12th c.	**Al-Shahrastani**, *Kitab al-Milal wa'l-Nihal* ("Book of Religions and Sects")

What he wrote: he divided Indians into groups (Brahmins, worshippers of spiritual beings, of stars, idol-worshippers, philosophers), e.g. the great **Mahakala** idol at **Ujjain**, and explained why Brahmins "reject prophets".

Strengths (Khan)

- **Preserves** medieval knowledge that might be lost
- **Systematic** classification of Indian religions
- **Comparative**: places Indian beliefs beside others
- **Fair**: reports faithfully, does not insult Indian religions
- **Unique** details on Buddhism
- Understood that Hindus believe God himself comes down (**avatar**), unlike a prophet who brings a book

but

Weaknesses (Khan)

- **Never visited India**; knew no Sanskrit or Pali
- Copied older **Arabic** books (secondary sources); didn't even use al-Biruni
- Errors: "**Brahma**" as a man's name; Buddhism as a branch of Hinduism; the Buddha dated "5,000 years" before Islam
- **Omits** the Vedas and Jainism
- Judged through **Islamic** ideas: didn't see that idols can be symbols

Khan's fair conclusion: it is "futile to expect scientific accuracy from an author of the twelfth century"; judge him by what Arabic information was available then.

Al-Biruni vs al-Shahrastani

	Al-Biruni (973–1048)	Al-Shahrastani (1086–1153)
Visited India?	Yes	No
Knew Sanskrit?	Yes (even translated the Yoga Sutras into Arabic)	No
Sources	Original Indian texts (**primary**)	Arabic compilations (**secondary**)
Style	Critical scholarship	Compilation

CLEVER POINT FOR ANSWERS

Historians trust **al-Biruni** more. But al-Shahrastani is still valuable as evidence of **what 12th-century Muslims believed about India**. The value of a source depends on the question you ask (Backerra, S2).

Chinese pilgrims vs Arab scholars

	Chinese pilgrims	Arab scholar (al-Shahrastani)
Motive	Pilgrimage	Intellectual inquiry
Framework	Buddhism	Comparative religion (Islamic categories)

Evidence	First-hand observation	Mostly books
Focus	Monasteries, relics, monastery rules	Classifying religions

CORROBORATION: THE KEY METHOD

Check each account against **inscriptions** (official and dated), **archaeology** (physical proof), **Indian literature** (the insiders' view) and **coins**. **Bigger meaning:** travellers show India was **deeply connected** with Asia. Knowledge travelled with merchants, Buddhism linked India and China, and Islamic scholarship linked India with West Asia.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. How useful are foreign travellers' accounts as sources for Indian history?

Where Indian records are scarce, foreign accounts are very useful, but travel writing mixes **observation, memory, interpretation and opinion**, so it is evidence and interpretation at once. Historians must ask why the traveller came, for whom they wrote, what languages they knew, and what they left out.

The Chinese pilgrims were **eyewitnesses**. Faxian (399–413) described Gupta India, relic worship and his sea voyage home. Xuanzang described Harsha's Kanauj and Nalanda, brought back 657 texts and opened diplomatic ties. Yijing recorded monastery rules and studied at Srivijaya. They also show monks travelling with merchants. **But** they saw India through a Buddhist lens, and their "borderland complex" made them idealise it.

Al-Shahrastani classified Indian religions systematically and fairly, **but** he never visited India, knew no Sanskrit, relied on older Arabic books and made errors (e.g. "Brahma" as a man). Al-Biruni, who learned Sanskrit and used original texts, is more reliable, though al-Shahrastani still shows what Muslims of his time believed.

So these accounts must be **corroborated** with inscriptions, coins and archaeology. Used critically, they also show that India was **connected** to Asia, not isolated.

SESSION 7

Baghdad to Canton: Commerce and Culture in the Medieval Indian Ocean

William Bernstein, *A Splendid Exchange*, ch. 4, "The Baghdad–Canton Express" (2008) + Lecture 7. Sources discussed: Marco Polo, *Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind*, *Marvels of India*, Ibn Battuta, Tomé Pires.

IN ONE LINE

Long before Europeans came, the Indian Ocean was a regular, lasting system of "premodern globalisation" from East Africa to China, run by monsoon winds, ports, merchant networks and shared rules (especially Islamic law), with India at the centre.

1. The big argument MUST KNOW

- The Indian Ocean was a major arena of **premodern globalisation**: not modern capitalism, but a **dense, regular system** of exchange over long distances.
- It was **patterned and lasting**, not occasional, linking **East Africa, the Middle East, India, Southeast Asia and China**, and it worked **before** European naval control. This challenges **Eurocentric** stories.
- Trade carried both luxury goods (spices, silk) and **bulk goods** (textiles, grain, horses, metals, timber), which mattered just as much.
- **India** sat in the **strategic middle**: central in geography, productive in goods and influential in culture; both a **destination** and a **relay point**.

What moved	Examples
Goods	Silk, spices, porcelain, **cotton cloth**, horses, ivory, incense, gold (each region supplied what others lacked)
People	Merchants, sailors, pilgrims, judges, envoys, carrying knowledge
Ideas	Religion (especially **Islam**), law, stories, technology
Institutions	Taxes, port rules, contracts, **credit**, which made **trust at a distance** possible

Key idea: trade rested on both material and cultural foundations; goods alone cannot explain how the system worked.

2. Picture it: the monsoon "timetable"



Ships could cross only at certain times, so merchants sailed in segments. Goods from Baghdad to Canton changed ships at least 3 times.

Monsoons shaped everything

Seasonal winds set **routes and sailing calendars**. Most merchants did **one segment**, not the whole route.

e.g. A Gujarati merchant sails on the summer monsoon to **Malacca** with cotton cloth and indigo, swaps for silk, spices and porcelain, and returns on the winter monsoon. Or he goes west to **Aden** (horses, incense) or **Malindi** (gold, slaves).

Nature shaped exchange: the Indian Ocean world was **ecological** as well as commercial.

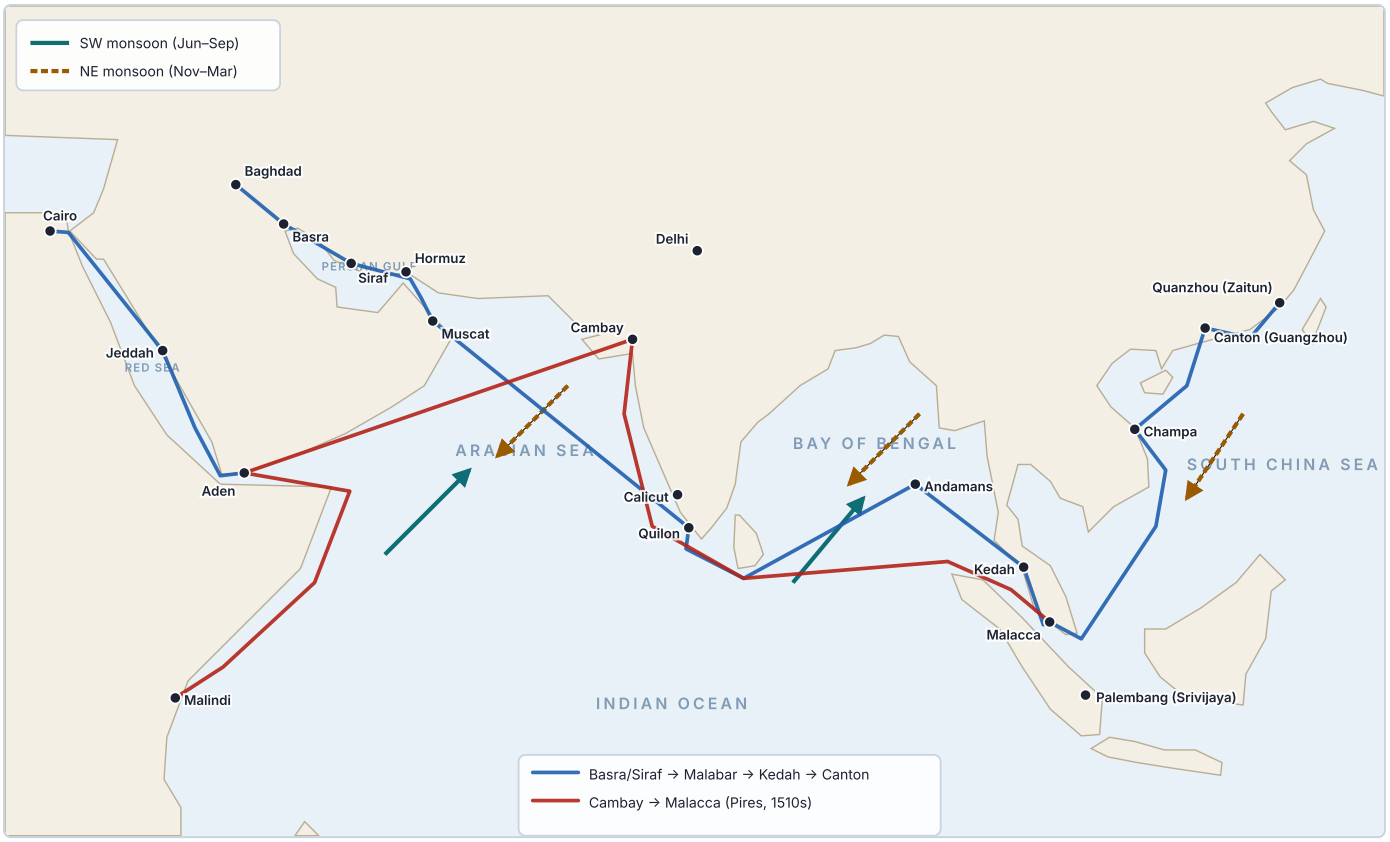
Danger, distance, risk

- Before the Chinese **magnetic compass** (c.12th c.) sailors used the stars; fog was as deadly as storms. Longitude could not be measured until the 18th century.
- Shipwreck, **piracy**, storms; a short trip could take over a year.
- Trade was profitable **because** it was risky: scarcity raised the value.
- Travellers' **exaggerations** are themselves evidence of how scary distance felt (source criticism).

3. Reading the sources: every account has its own angle MUST KNOW

Source	Who / when	Value and bias
Marco Polo, *Travels*	Venetian; dictated c.1292 in prison to Rustichello	Surprisingly accurate, but few economic details (no pepper prices); Rustichello added marvels for readers
Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind	c.851, Arab merchants (Sulayman), continued by Abu Zayd	Early account of the Baghdad–India–China route
Marvels of India	10th c., ship captain Buzurg ibn Shahriyar	Mixes real sailing life with fantasy (giants), but shows shipwreck, slavery and Islam's trade bonds
Ibn Battuta	14th c. Moroccan **qadi** (Muslim judge)	Legal and court view; little interest in trade or non-Muslims
Tomé Pires, *Suma Oriental*	Portuguese apothecary, from 1511	Precise numbers; admired Asian trade at the moment the Portuguese arrived

Others: Chau Ju-kua (Chinese trade inspector, a "reverse Marco Polo"); Benjamin of Tudela; Sinbad in the *Thousand and One Nights*; Ma Huan (Zheng He's interpreter). **Lesson:** each source shows what its author cared about: profit, piety, danger, power or curiosity.



The Baghdad–Canton sea route (Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind, 9th c.) and the later Cambay–Malacca axis (Pires). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

4. The story in 4 phases

Phase 1: Tang China + Abbasid caliphate, direct sea trade (7th–9th c.)

- Arab ("Ta-shih") and Persian ("Po-ssi") ships sailed direct to China; **trade diasporas** (Persians, Jews, Nestorian Christians) settled along the Chinese coast. By 758 Muslims in Canton were numerous enough to sack the city.
- **750**: the **Abbasids** moved Islam's capital to riverside **Baghdad**: "This is the Tigris; there is no obstacle between us and China."
- **The route** (from the *Akhbar*): Basra and Siraf → Oman → **Malabar** (one month) → across the Bay of Bengal → **Kedah** → Strait of Malacca → Vietnam → **Canton**. About 4 months of sailing in theory, over a year in practice.
- **At Canton**: the government held goods for 6 months, took a **30%** duty, and bought first. The *Akhbar* admired Chinese literacy and pensions and described **tea** (the West's first mention).
- *Marvels* story: traders enslave a kind East African king; years later, now a Muslim, he welcomes them back: "Muslims shall know they may come to us like brothers." This shows **slavery** and **Islam's power to bind traders**.
- **Collapse**: in **878**, **Huang Chao**'s rebels sacked Canton and killed about 120,000 foreign merchants. Trade moved north to **Quanzhou (Zaitun)**.
- "**Sinbad's way**" (Gulf route) was preferred over the Red Sea (pirates, reefs) and the overland Silk Road (slow, dangerous).

Phase 2: the Mongol window and Ibn Battuta (13th–14th c.)

- The Mongols sacked Baghdad in **1258**; for about a century a chain of Mongol states kept routes open (used by the Polos and Ibn Battuta).

- **Ibn Battuta** (born Tangier, 1304), a **qadi**, travelled about 74,000 miles. In **Delhi** under **Muhammad bin Tughluq** (1325–51), who recruited foreign scholars with huge rewards, newcomers gave the sultan costly gifts paid for with **merchants' loans**, repaid from his bigger return gift (credit + patronage). Battuta became qadi of Delhi, ran up a 55,000-dinar debt, then was sent as **ambassador to China**.
- He saw **Samudera** (Sumatra, 1345), the first Muslim-ruled place in Southeast Asia, at the start of the conversion that made Indonesia the world's largest Muslim nation.
- **Shared commercial code:** a Muslim importer in Cairo and his supplier in Cambay followed the same religious and commercial rules. **Customs: 2.5% for Muslims, 5% for Christians and Jews, 10% for others.** The **hajj** united the trading world (Jeddah became a great market). Yet the ocean was "**no Muslim lake**": Calicut had a Hindu ruler (the zamorin).

Phase 3: Zheng He's treasure fleets (1405–1433)

- Chinese ships had iron nails, watertight compartments, rudders and the compass; Indian Ocean **dhows** were **sewn** with coconut fibre (more flexible on reefs; little iron available).
- **Zheng He**, a Muslim eunuch admiral, led **7 voyages** of about 300 ships and 30,000 men to Malacca, India, Hormuz and East Africa. The purpose was **diplomatic, military and symbolic**, not trade. He made **Malacca** safe from pirates and from Siam, and brought back **giraffes**.
- After 1433 Confucian officials **stopped** the voyages; later big ships were banned. Bernstein: centralised China could **switch off** contact, while the **decentralised** Indian Ocean had "Darwinian" competition among ports.
- Modern China uses Zheng He as a symbol of "peaceful" policy, but his fleets also killed those who refused homage: a **political use of the past** (S1).

Phase 4: Tomé Pires and Malacca on the eve of the Portuguese (c.1500) MUST KNOW

Cambay ↔ Malacca: the main axis

"Cambay with her right arm reaches towards Aden, and with the other towards Malacca." Pires praised the **Gujaratis**: "they have the **cream of the trade**... our people who want to be clerks and factors ought to go there and learn." Praise from a proud Portuguese "spoke volumes".

Why Malacca succeeded

Founded c.1400 by **Parameswara**, a prince of Palembang (Srivijaya's line). Pires counted **84 languages**; four harbourmasters handled different regions.

- **Low duties** (at most 6%; less for settled merchants)
- **Honest courts** and officials
- A **transparent auction**, a "medieval eBay"

e.g. Success came from **institutions**, not just location. It fell to the Portuguese in **1511**.

ISLAM AND TRADE

Parameswara converted to Islam (marrying a Pase princess, for protection). Islam's law covers commerce, so becoming Muslim "did wonders for one's **credit rating**". Southeast Asia was converted **not by conquerors** but by cloth and spice **merchants** from Cambay and Calicut who married local women and raised their children Muslim.

5. Why India was central (lecture: 6 reasons) MUST KNOW

1. Intermediary

Western and eastern circuits met at Indian ports, where cargo was sorted, taxed and re-shipped. Centrality can come from **connecting**, not only producing.

2. Gujarat & Cambay

One of the most skilled trading regions, linked to the Gulf, Red Sea, East Africa and Southeast Asia.

3. Textiles

"If spices were glamorous, **cloth was indispensable**." Indian cotton reached ordinary consumers and was exchanged for spices, silk and porcelain.

4. Malabar & pepper

Calicut was built around pepper; Chinese demand was huge. Asian markets were powerful **in their own right** (decentring Europe).

5. Ibn Battuta's India

The Delhi Sultanate attracted scholars from across Islam: India as a hub of talent, credit and patronage in the Muslim world.

6. Delhi and the coast

Inland power and sea trade were linked but separate. Coastal wealth depended on **security, fair taxes and efficient ports**, under both Muslim and Hindu rulers.

India as a cultural carrier: Indian Muslim traders carried Islam east, and trade networks **came before** political conversion: "religious change often happens through households and trade, not just armies." **Malacca mattered largely because of India**: Gujarati and Malabari traders were among its most important merchants.

CONCLUSION

Premodern globalisation was **real** long before Europe; **Europe entered an already-connected world** as a late participant, not its creator; India was central in geography, economy, institutions and culture; later empires built on, disrupted and took over these structures. "To study the history of trade is to study the making of connected worlds." (But it was not all "peaceful": slavery, piracy and violence existed.)

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. Why was India central to the Indian Ocean trading system before 1500?

Bernstein shows that the medieval Indian Ocean was a form of **premodern globalisation**, a regular system linking East Africa, Arabia, India, Southeast Asia and China, organised by monsoons, ports, merchant networks and shared institutions. India sat at its centre, but not just because of geography.

First, monsoon voyages were done in segments, so ships from the west and east met at Indian ports, and India acted as the **intermediary** where cargo was sorted, taxed and re-shipped. Second, India was a great **producer**: its cotton textiles were "indispensable" across Asia, and Malabar pepper was in huge demand in China. Third, the **Gujarati** merchants of Cambay were so skilled that Tomé Pires told the Portuguese to learn from them; they dominated Malacca, which had 84 languages. Fourth, Indian Muslim traders spread **Islam** to Southeast Asia through trade and marriage, and Delhi under Tughluq drew scholars like Ibn Battuta.

But centrality also depended on institutions: safe ports, fair taxes and shared Islamic commercial law (customs of 2.5%, 5% or 10%), as Malacca's success shows.

So Europe entered an **already-connected world**; it did not create it.

SESSION 8

Silk Route Connections I: Overland Networks ("Comparing Two Lenses")

Valerie Hansen, *The Silk Road: A New History*, ch. 5 (Chang'an / Xi'an) · Jayati Bhattacharya, "Old Routes, New Dreams: the Southern Silk Road and Bengal–China Connectivities" (2021) + Lecture 8

IN ONE LINE

"There is no single Silk Road, only many histories of connection." Hansen looks through a city (Chang'an); Bhattacharya looks through a region (Bengal). The lens you choose decides which Silk Road you see.

1. What is the "Silk Road"? MUST KNOW

Popular view vs reality

Popular view: one overland road from China to the West, mainly for silk and luxuries.

Britannica (lecture): about 6,400 km from **Xi'an**, along the Great Wall, around the **Taklamakan** desert, over the **Pamirs**, through Afghanistan to the Mediterranean. **Few people travelled the whole way**; goods passed from **middleman to middleman**.

The name was coined in **1877** by the German geographer **Ferdinand von Richthofen**, who drew it as **one line** on a map (he was planning a railway).

The readings show: many routes carrying people, religions, ideas, goods, states and ecologies.

How it worked (lecture)

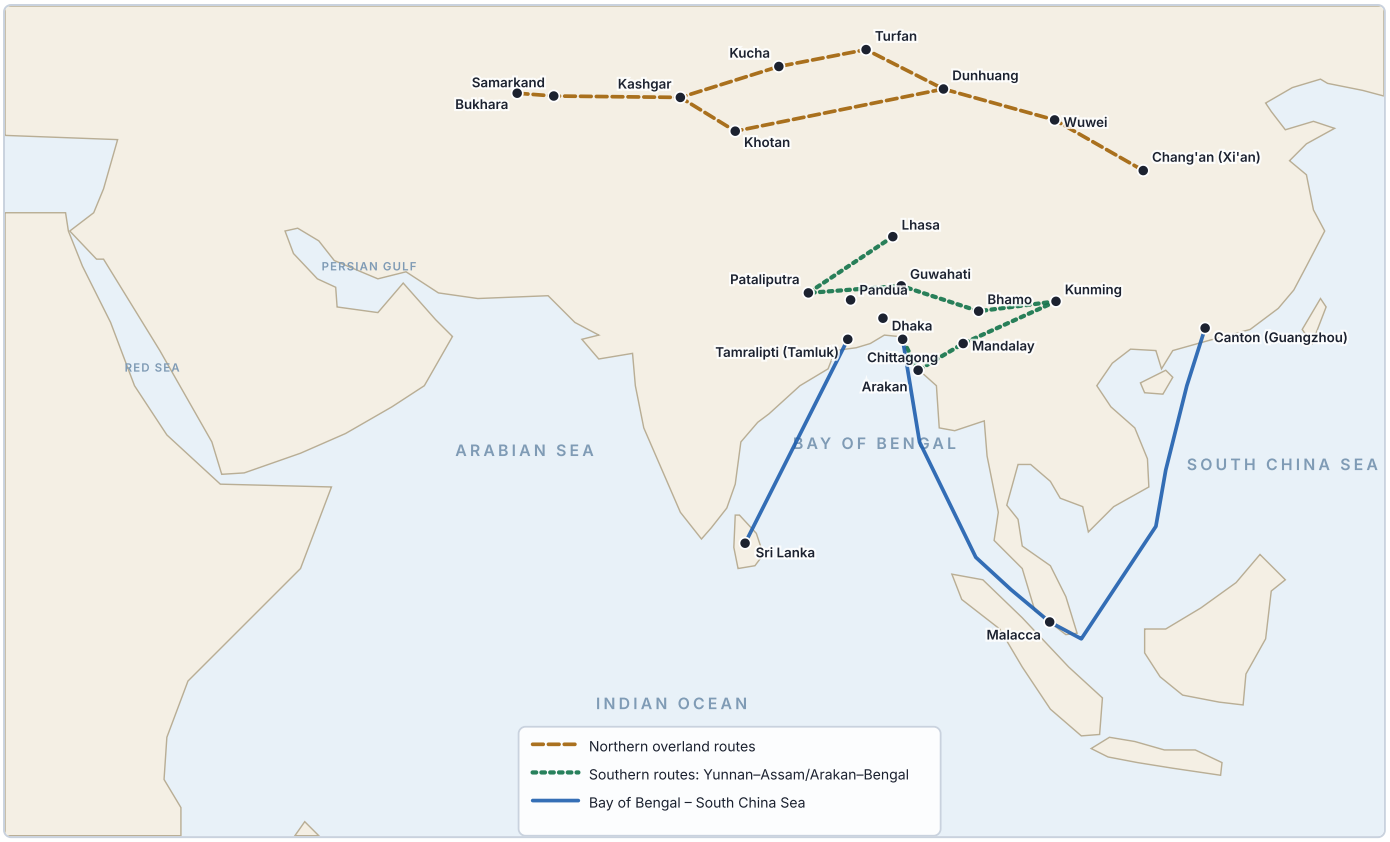
- Goods moved by trade but also as **gifts and dowries**.

  e.g. Han rulers kept peace by giving silk to the **Xiongnu** nomads.

- **Cosmopolitan centres**: Chang'an, Samarkand, Dunhuang
- **Religions** spread: Buddhism, Christianity, Manichaeism, Zoroastrianism
- **Art**: the Dunhuang caves, Sogdian paintings in Samarkand

People on the move MUST KNOW

Group	Role
Sogdians	Iranian merchants from **Samarkand**; ran caravan trade and lived in diasporas; even became officials (*sabao* headmen)
Muslim merchants	Took over after the Sogdians declined (8th c.); lived in Chang'an and China's ports
Christians, Jews, Italians	Nestorian Christians spread to India and China; Jewish documents (the Cairo Geniza; a Hebrew prayer found at Dunhuang); Italians sent envoys to the Mongol **Yuan** court
Indians & Armenians	Dominated trade from the 17th century (horses, spices)
Buddhist monks	Indian monks **Kasyapa Matanga** and **Dharmaraksa** went to China (57–75 CE, invited by Emperor Ming); **Faxian**, **Xuanzang** and **Yijing** travelled to India (S6)



Two lenses: Chang'an as terminus (Hansen) and Bengal as circulatory centre (Bhattacharya). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

2. The two lenses MUST KNOW

	Valerie Hansen	Jayati Bhattacharya
Unit / scale	**City**: Chang'an (Xi'an)	**Region**: Bengal, Bay of Bengal, Yunnan, Himalayas
Method	**Archaeology**: tombs, objects; urban history; migration	**Space and commodities**; ecology; geopolitics; long-term history
In short	From "luxury trade" to **city cosmopolitanism** and daily cultural mixing	From "frontier/periphery" to **circulatory centrality** (Bengal as a hub)
On trade	**Doubts** big trade volumes; small, valuable goods; **people and ideas mattered more**	**Uses goods** (cotton, cowries, horses, silver) to map regional systems
Change over time	Rise under the Sui and Tang → rebellion and persecution → shift to **sea** routes	Old circulation → **colonial rerouting** → post-1947 closure → selective 21st-century **revival**

Shared argument: both reject the narrow "silk-for-the-West" story and "only capitals matter" history; both stress **people on the move** and the cultural and political meaning of routes. "Connectivity is not just movement; it is how spaces become meaningful through movement."

3. Hansen: Chang'an, the cosmopolitan end of the Silk Road MUST KNOW

HANSEN'S ARGUMENT

Chang'an was a truly **international city**, home to monks, merchants, craftsmen, officials and refugees. But **few bulk goods** came overland; trade volumes were **smaller than popular memory suggests**. What mattered most was the movement of **people, skills and ideas**. Her evidence is mainly **archaeological**.

The city

- Capital of the **Han, Sui and Tang** (618–907) dynasties; about **1 million** people
- A planned grid of **109 walled wards** with a night curfew
- **Two markets**: Eastern (local goods) and **Western** (foreign goods, inns, Sogdian traders)
- The **Tang Code** banned high officials from markets (trade was seen as "polluting"); officials set prices
- **Law for foreigners**: same nationality → their own law; different nationalities → Chinese law

Foreigners and religions

- Foreigners came through treaties (Turks, 631), as **hostage princes**, or as refugees (Persian princes after the Muslim conquest of Iran)
- **Zoroastrian** temples near the Western Market
- The **Nestorian stele (781)** records a Christian monk, Aluohan, arriving in 635
- The **Big Goose Pagoda** (for Xuanzang's texts) survives

Archaeological evidence (her key examples)

Sogdian tombs: mixing of cultures

An Jia (d. 579), a ***sabao*** (headman of the foreign community): his tomb is **Chinese in shape** but has a **Zoroastrian fire altar** and a stone bed instead of a coffin. The carvings show diplomacy, not commerce.

Shi Wirkak (d. 579): a stone "house" with a **bilingual Sogdian–Chinese** epitaph and the soul crossing the Zoroastrian **Chinwad bridge** to paradise.

e.g. Lesson: migrants **adapted** Chinese practices and mixed them with their own ("hybridity").

Pawn tickets and the Hejiacun hoard

Pawnshop tickets (660s–680s, later reused to make a figurine): ordinary people pawned clothes at 5% a month, and about **a quarter of the customers were women**. This is everyday life, not grand trade.

Hejiacun hoard (found **1970**): over 1,000 items, but only **a few imports** (gems, a glass bowl, a Persian coin); most were made **in China by migrant Sogdian craftsmen**.

e.g. Fewer than **50 Roman coins** found in all of China (many used as charms); silk was often used as **money** (to pay soldiers). Objects correct the myth of endless luxury caravans.

Decline: change over time

- **An Lushan rebellion (755–763)**, led by a Sogdian-Turkish general. Afterwards the Tang **blamed Sogdians**; in one account people with "big noses" were killed, the first time a Chinese ruler targeted a minority.
- Tibetans looted Chang'an (763); in 787 minister Li Mi cut support for **4,000 foreign envoys** who had settled there.
- **Stereotype vs reality:** tales show Sogdians as fabulously rich jewel merchants, but most were soldiers, farmers, envoys and craftsmen. **A stereotype is not proof of a rich trade.**
- **843–845:** foreign religions (Manichaeism, Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, Christianity) banned. Land routes declined, and travel shifted to the **sea**. **Huang Chao**'s rebels killed foreigners at Guangzhou (878) and burned Chang'an; the Tang ended in 907.

4. Bhattacharya: Bengal and the Southern Silk Road MUST KNOW

BHATTACHARYA'S ARGUMENT

New policies, India's **Look/Act East** and China's **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)**, have revived memories of old routes once called "frontier" or "periphery". She argues **Bengal was central**: a hub linking the delta, rivers, Himalayas, Tibet, Burma (Arakan) and **Yunnan** (China) with the sea. It was "peripheral" only from the viewpoint of rulers far from the sea (Delhi, Beijing). The "Silk Route" was a **web** of land, river and sea paths (a "Southern Silk Road" or even a "**Cotton Road**").

Useful concepts she uses

- **The periphery is constructed** (Yang Bin, van Schendel)
- **Zomia** (James Scott): the stateless uplands of Southeast Asia
- Tirthankar Roy: Bengal as "parallel globalizations"
- **Braudel's *longue durée*** (long term) vs short "episodic" political history
- Wallerstein put South Asia in the "semi-periphery"; Washbrook, Bayly and Ludden criticised this as Eurocentric

Bengal's history in "episodes"

- **Buddhism** flourished under the **Palas** (Tamralipti port, visited by Xuanzang)
- The **Senas** revived Brahmanism
- **Ilyas Shahi** sultans (from 1342) broke from Delhi: two centuries of autonomy
- **Zheng He's** fleets reached Pandua (1415) and Gaur (1432)
- Colonial era: **Plassey 1757**, Calcutta as "London of the East", partitions in **1905** and **1947**

Four old trade corridors: (1) Tibet–Bhutan–Nepal–Bengal; (2) Yunnan–Arakan–Bengal; (3) Ganga river networks; (4) Assam–Bengal. Horses came through Himalayan passes; Tibet traded gold, salt, musk and wool. China is "Cina" in the Mahabharata, and the Arthashastra mentions Chinese silk; the Chinese envoy **Zhang Qian** noted India–China trade before the 2nd century BC. Main goods: **silver, horses, cotton cloth, cowries**.

Case 1: cotton, the "Cotton Road"

Chinese writers praised Bengal's fine **cotton (muslin)**, and China kept buying Indian cotton even after growing its own (Stephen Dale). Chinese names for the route include the "Road of the Shu Cloth".

e.g. Why "Silk Road" and not "Cotton Road"? Richthofen's name stuck, and Bengal was imagined as a **periphery**.

Case 2: cowrie shells

Small shells used as **cheap money** from the **Maldives** through Bengal to **Yunnan**, mentioned by Faxian, Xuanzang, Yijing, Ibn Battuta and Tomé Pires.

e.g. In Bengal a chicken cost about 448 cowries.

Where cowries spread **maps how far the Southern Silk Road reached**.

The professor said you may skip: the detailed lists of route towns (Bhamo, Myitkyina and so on), the 15th-century Chinese sources on Bengal, the post-1947 transition paragraph, and the conclusion's details on Siliguri and Nathu La.

Colonial rule restructured the routes

- Colonialism **restructured** mobility rather than simply expanding it: new institutions, railways, steamships, **borders**
- Warren Hastings sent missions to **Bhutan and Tibet** (Bogle, 1774) to tap trade; the British annexed the **Duars** (1841–65)
- **Tea** in Assam; the Permanent Settlement; Bengal's **textile industry declined**, and wealth flowed out to Britain
- The Younghusband mission to Tibet (1904); the **Ledo (Stilwell) Road** to China (1942)
- Moving the capital to **Delhi in 1912** made Bengal "peripheral"

After 1947: walls go up

Partition (1947), the **1962 India–China war**, Communist China and the Cold War built "huge walls". Regional groups such as **ASEAN (1967)** and **SAARC (1985)** split South and Southeast Asia. "The cowrie connections were soon chapters of a forgotten history."

21st century: old routes, new politics MUST KNOW

India

Look East Policy (1990s, PM Narasimha Rao) → Vajpayee's car rally (2004) → **Act East Policy** (PM Modi, **2014**). Focused on the North-East; partly a hedge against China.

vs

China

Belt and Road Initiative (Xi Jinping, **2013**): a land "belt" and a 21st-century "Maritime Silk Road". Big investment in Myanmar, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka. **India has not joined BRI.**

Groupings in the Bay of Bengal: BIMSTEC (1997; the Kaladan project and the India–Myanmar–Thailand highway); **BBIN** (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal); **BCIM** (Bangladesh–China–Myanmar–India; the Kolkata–Kunming car rally, 2013).

HER CRITICAL CONCLUSION: THE POLITICAL USE OF THE PAST

States use history **selectively** (facts and legends) for diplomacy. BRI treats the "Silk Route", which "at no point in history was a single route", as **one road** led by China, pushing South Asian routes to the margins. Act East also treats the North-East as a periphery run from Delhi. There is a **gap between policy and real history**. This is **Hobsbawm's symbolic restoration and invented past** (S1).

5. The seven lenses on Silk Road connectivity (lecture) MUST KNOW

Lens	Hansen	Bhattacharya
1 Urban	Chang'an: markets, migrants, daily life	(not central)
2 Regional-spatial	(the city as one node)	The **macro-region** as the key unit
3 Archaeology	Tombs, hoards, pawn tickets	Buddhist sites in Bengal
4 Ecology & geography	Oasis routes; the shift to sea	Rivers, passes, delta: **routes change because ecologies change**
5 Migration	Sogdians, monks, refugees	Merchants, caravans, diasporas

6 Religion	Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, Christianity in one city	Buddhism on Bengal–China routes; religion **created** routes
7 Commodities	**Sceptical** of trade volume	**Traces** cotton, cowries, horses, silver

Scale

City, region, empire or ocean: each gives a **different Silk Road**. Always ask "at what scale?"

Centre and periphery are made

Chang'an's greatness depended on "outsiders"; Bengal was later **labelled** peripheral by politics.

Connectivity has a history

It grows, shrinks, reroutes and gets **reimagined**. Are BRI and Act East reviving the past or **inventing useful pasts**?

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. "There is no single Silk Road." Discuss with reference to Hansen and Bhattacharya.

The term "Silk Road" was coined by Richthofen in 1877 as one line from China to Europe, but the readings show a **web of routes** carrying people, religions and many goods, with few people travelling the whole way.

Hansen uses a **city lens**. Through archaeology in Chang'an (An Jia's Chinese tomb with a Zoroastrian altar, the Hejiacun hoard, pawn tickets) she shows a cosmopolitan city where foreigners mixed cultures, but where **few goods** travelled far. Most items were made locally by migrant craftsmen, so people and skills mattered more. After the An Lushan rebellion (755) and the bans of 843–845, the city declined and trade moved to the sea.

Bhattacharya uses a **regional lens**. Bengal was a **hub** linking rivers, mountains and sea to Yunnan and Southeast Asia, shown by trade in cotton (a "Cotton Road") and cowrie shells. Colonial rule restructured these routes, and 1947 and 1962 closed them, making Bengal "peripheral".

Today, China's BRI (2013) and India's Act East (2014) use the Silk Road memory **selectively**, a political use of the past. So the Silk Road was **multiple and changing**, and what we see depends on the lens and scale we choose.

SESSION 9

Silk Route Connections II: Trade, Religion and Buddhism Across the Sea

Tansen Sen, "Buddhism and the Maritime Crossings" (2014) + Lecture 9

IN ONE LINE

Buddhism reached China by sea as well as by land, carried by monks on merchant ships. Trade and religion supported each other, Southeast Asia was first only a stop-over, and later Srivijaya and Sri Lanka became major Buddhist hubs.

1. Sen's main argument: 6 claims MUST KNOW

1. **Critique of the "Silk Road" focus:** scholars studied only the overland routes; one book on Buddhism's spread had **not a single chapter** on the sea. The term "**maritime Silk Road**" is misleading.
2. **Buddhism and sea trade were tied together**, just as on land.
3. **"Long-distance", not "contact" transmission** (Erik Zürcher's idea): in the first centuries CE, maritime Southeast Asia was only a "**transit zone**" where monks changed ships.
4. **India–China sea networks** were cosmopolitan: Indian, Sogdian and Central Asian merchants and monks, Sri Lankan nuns, Southeast Asian kings.
5. **Sri Lanka** was not only the home of Theravada; it was also a centre of **relics** and **Tantric** Buddhism.
6. **Sea networks lasted longer** than land networks (into the 19th–20th centuries).

2. Why "Maritime Silk Road" is a misleading name MUST KNOW

Sen's 3 objections

1. **Silk was not the main cargo** at sea. Early trade was in **beads, precious stones, pearls**; later in bulk goods like **incense, pepper, spices, porcelain**.
2. It **over-stresses China**. Ports and ships from **Southeast Asia, India and the Middle East** were just as important, and **the Chinese became active in Indian Ocean shipping only from the 10th century**.
3. It **ignores Southeast Asia**, whose rise was crucial for the sea route.

Alternative: see maritime Asia as a **multi-centred** world, not a China-centred extension of the Silk Road.

The sea was busy long before Buddhism

- **2500–1500 BCE**: **Austronesian** migrations linked south China, Southeast Asia and Indonesia
- 1st millennium BCE: metal and **wet-rice farming** spread; Southeast Asian sailors were as important as Indian ones (they exported tin and gold)
- 1st c. CE: **Funan** (Mekong delta), with its port **Oc Eo**, trans-shipped goods between India and China
- **Indo-Roman trade**: Roman coins in Tamil Nadu, in exchange for **pepper and textiles**
- Han China's ports (**Jiaozhi, Hepu, Guangzhou**) received ivory, pearls and incense; with these traders came **Buddhist preachers and texts**

3. Land or sea first? Sen's way out of an old debate

The old debate

Sea first: Liang Qichao, Paul Pelliot.
Land first (traditional view): Tang Yongtong, Rong Xinjiang.

→

Sen: the debate is "irrelevant"

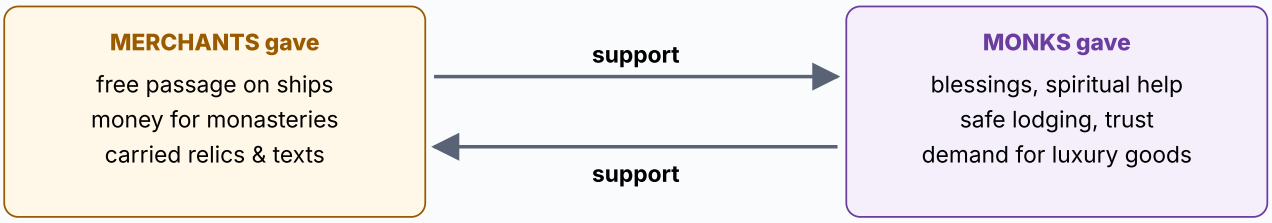
There were **no monasteries** on either route before the 4th century, by which time Buddhism was already in China. Evidence shows **both**: Buddhist carvings at **Mount Kongwang** (coast) point to the sea; Buddha figures in **Sichuan tombs** point to land. **Multiple routes**, not one.

"LONG-DISTANCE" VS "CONTACT" TRANSMISSION (ZÜRCHER)

Contact transmission works like a relay race: each region adopts Buddhism, builds monasteries, then passes it on. **Long-distance transmission** works like a long-haul flight: monks and texts go **straight from India to China**, and the places in between are only **stop-overs**. Zürcher showed that Central Asian towns became Buddhist centres only from the mid-3rd century; Sen applies the same idea to the sea.

Better question (Sen): study how land and sea were **complementary, connected and sometimes competing**. Many monks used both. Mahayana grew on the land routes; Theravada later on the sea routes. The lecture calls this balanced view (sea did not "replace" land) one of the article's **greatest strengths**.

4. Monks and merchants: partners, but not always friends MUST KNOW



Lecture: religion did not just travel alongside trade; it became part of trade itself. Buddhism spread because trade networks already existed.

Partnership (the usual view)

James Heitzman: in India, monasteries stood near trade towns and routes, in **mutual support** with merchants. **Xinru Liu** applied this to India–China.

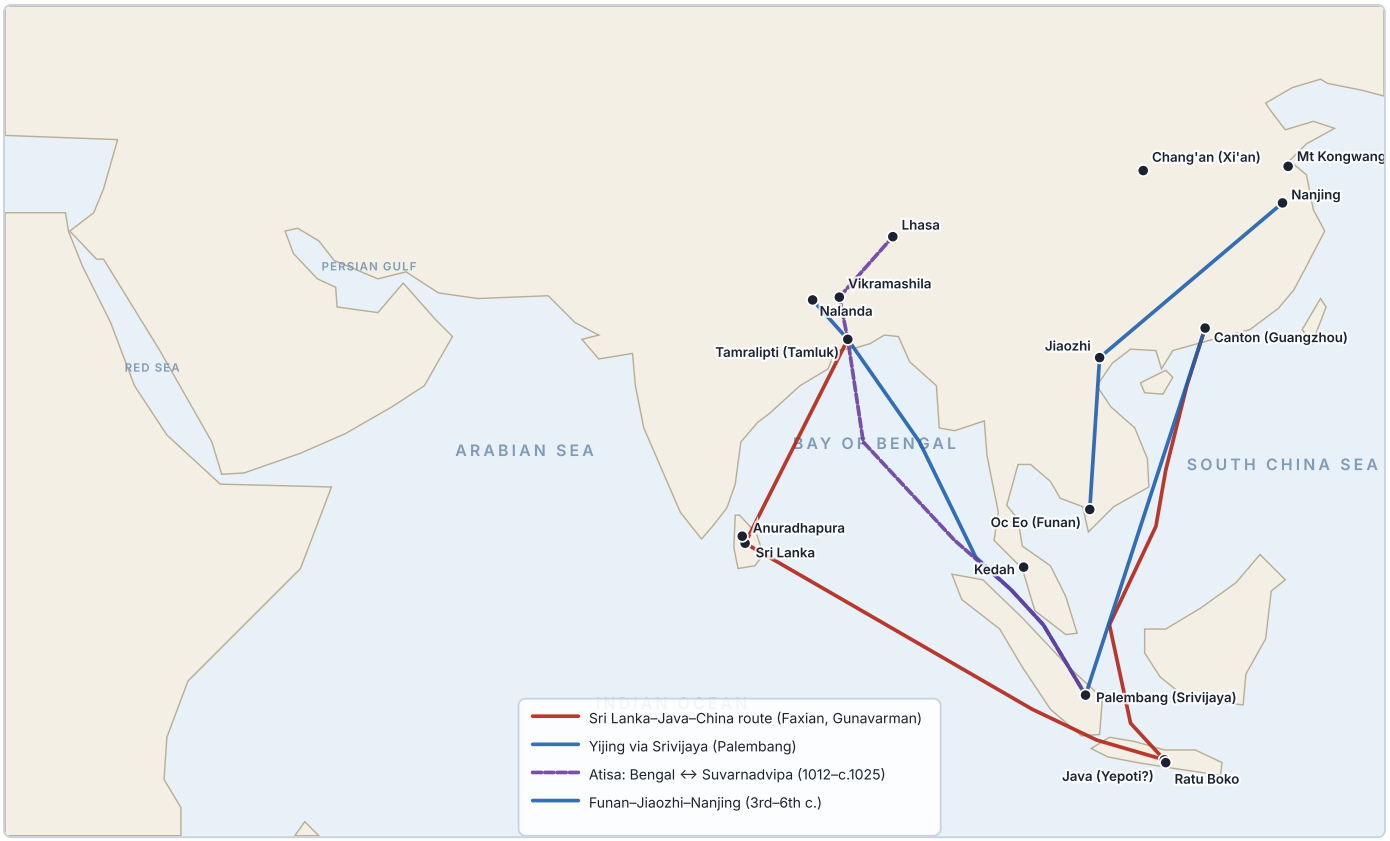
e.g. The Buddhist "**seven jewels**" (*saptaratna*) offered to monasteries created demand for **pearls, coral and lapis lazuli** from India.

Antagonism (Sen's addition)

Merchants had their own gods and loyalties; some were **Brahmanical** or later **Muslim**, and they might compete over the trade in relics and texts.

e.g. In a storm in 411, "**Brahmin**" merchants on **Faxian**'s ship blamed him for bad luck and wanted to leave him on an island. His patron threatened to report them to the Chinese ruler, and they backed down.

5. The India–China sea network (3rd–6th c.) MUST KNOW



Maritime Buddhist networks (Tansen Sen). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Mount Kongwang (Chinese coast): Buddhist carvings mixed with Daoist ones, and donors in **Central Asian** dress. Why Central Asians at sea? The **Kushan** empire joined land and sea trade networks; **trade, diplomacy and religion were intertwined**.

Person	Remember
Kang Senghui (d. 280)	A **Sogdian** monk whose merchant family lived in India; grew up in **Jiaozhi** (Vietnam); spread Buddhism in south China (Nanjing). Shows Sogdian sea traders in Southeast Asia.
Kang Tai	Envoy sent by the Chinese ruler Sun Quan to **Funan**, perhaps to boost trade
Monks via Guangzhou	**Gunavarman**, **Gunabhadra**, **Paramartha**, **Bodhidharma** (4th–6th c.) came by sea; Guangzhou was a Buddhist centre from the 3rd century
Nandin, the ship-owner (5th c.)	An Indian ship-owner who carried **Gunavarman** and two groups of **Sri Lankan nuns** to China and helped translate texts: the **clearest merchant–Buddhism link**
Gunavarman's route	Sri Lanka → **Java** (spread Buddhism there) → Nanjing (431)

Faxian's voyage home (411–412)

Tamralipti → **Sri Lanka** → a ship of 200+ people, a storm on day 3, about 90 days to **Yepoti** (Java or Sumatra) → after 5 months another ship → blown off course → landed in **north China**. "There is no knowing east or west; only by observing the sun, moon and stars…" He found **no Buddhism at Yepoti**, which supports the transit-zone idea.

The shipping route shifted (5th c.)

Earlier, **Funan's port Oc Eo** was the key stop. From the 5th century **Java, Sumatra and Kedah** (Malay peninsula) became the main centres, so later monks passed through the Indonesian islands.

6. Southeast Asia: from transit zone to Buddhist centre MUST KNOW

1st–4th c.
Just a **stop-over**: ships changed crews and took supplies; no monasteries

→

5th c.
First Buddhist inscription, by the sea captain **Buddhagupta** (Kedah)

→

7th–13th c.
Srivijaya (Sumatra): Mahayana and Tantric hub

→

12th c. on
Theravada networks with Sri Lanka

Evidence for the transit zone (lecture): no monasteries before the 4th–5th centuries; Buddhist inscriptions appear late; Buddhist institutions grow **alongside** sea trade. Sea traffic between India and China even **helped establish** Buddhism in Southeast Asia.

Srivijaya (Palembang, Sumatra)

- Controlled the sea route between India and China
- Used Buddhism in **diplomacy**: gifts to monasteries at **Nalanda**, **Nagapattinam** and Thailand (S10)
- **Yijing**: over **1,000 monks** there, following the same rules as India; Chinese monks should study there **1–2 years** before going to India. His book lists 60 Chinese monks, many travelling by sea.
- Lecture: India no longer had a **monopoly** on Buddhist knowledge; it was spread across maritime Asia.

Tantric Buddhism in Srivijaya

- Inscriptions (e.g. 684) show Tantric ideas
- Tantric masters **Vajrabodhi** and **Amoghavajra** passed through to China (8th c.)
- **Atisa** (982–1054), an Indian prince-monk, went to Srivijaya in **1012** to study under **Dharmakirti** for about 12–13 years, then taught at **Vikramashila** and went to **Tibet** (1040s). **Knowledge flowed back to India.**

7. Sri Lanka reinterpreted MUST KNOW

LECTURE: "PERHAPS THE MOST SIGNIFICANT CONTRIBUTION OF THIS ARTICLE"

Most histories call Sri Lanka simply the centre of **Theravada**. Sen shows it was also a **transit point** (from the 4th c.), a **store of relics**, a staging point for pilgrims, a centre of **Mahayana and Tantric** Buddhism, and a **diplomatic actor**. Faxian, Vajrabodhi, Amoghavajra and Atisa all passed through. Its monasteries were **crossroads**, not isolated.

Relics = power

Faxian saw the **Bodhi tree** sapling and the **tooth relic** festival. Kings believed relics had magical and political power:

- **Candrabhanu**, a Malay king, attacked Sri Lanka (**1247, 1262**) to get relics
- **Kublai Khan** sent an envoy (**1284**), perhaps for the alms bowl
- **Zheng He** captured a Sri Lankan ruler (**1410**), probably wanting the tooth relic

Tantra and the Abhayagiri monastery

Vajrabodhi worshipped the tooth relic for 6 months at **Abhayagiri** before sailing to China (719–20). **Amoghavajra** went there in 741 to collect Tantric texts and returned with a royal mission (746). Around 800 the head of **Vikramashila** (India's top Tantric monastery) was a Sri Lankan monk, **Jayabhadra**.

RATU BOKO, JAVA (792): COPIED, BUT ADAPTED

A Javanese inscription names "the **Abhayagiri Vihara** of the **Sinhalese**", a second Abhayagiri in Java (de Casparis). Its platforms resemble Sri Lanka's (Miksic) but face a **different direction** (north–south, not east–west), showing **local adaptation**, not simple copying (Degroot).

Later Theravada networks (11th–15th c.): when the **Cholas** invaded Sri Lanka, monks fled to **Myanmar**; after King **Vijayabahu I** freed the island, Sri Lankan and Burmese monks **restored Buddhism together**. Close ties followed with Myanmar, Thailand and Cambodia. **Modern echo: Anagarika Dharmapala** (1864–1933) travelled by sea to spread Buddhism worldwide.

8. Long-term change and conclusion

Early (1st–5th c.)	**India** → **China**; Southeast Asia is a transit zone
Middle (7th–11th c.)	Srivijaya and Sri Lanka as hubs; Mahayana and **Tantric** networks
Later (11th c. on)	**Sri Lanka** → **Southeast Asia**: Theravada networks (Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia)
13th c.	Land routes become dominated by **Islamic** exchange, but sea Buddhism **continues**
19th–20th c.	Chinese migrants (e.g. in **Calcutta**) and the monk **Taixu** revive India–China Buddhist links

9. Evaluating Sen (lecture) MUST KNOW

Strengths

1. **Connected history**, not separate national histories
2. **The sea as an active space**, not empty water
3. **Networks** matter more than political borders
4. Trade and religion **reinforce** each other
5. Uses many kinds of evidence (archaeology, inscriptions, travel accounts, chronicles)
6. Balanced: land and sea **complement** each other
7. Shows people, objects, texts and ideas travelling **together**

but

Limitations

1. Relies heavily on **Chinese texts** (Faxian, Yijing)
2. **Little local agency**: Southeast Asians appear only as middle-men, while recent research stresses local adaptation (e.g. Ratu Boko)
3. Treats **merchants as one group** (Tamil guilds, Arabs, Malays and Gujaratis differed)
4. **Gender almost absent** (only the Sri Lankan nuns)

10. Old routes, new politics

- China's **OBOR → BRI**: Xi Jinping's main foreign policy; capital flows into **Central Asia** and serves Chinese steel and coal industries. **India has not joined**.
- The "**Southern Silk Road**" (Yunnan–Myanmar–India) is back in political talk, though local trade there "**never ceased**".
- Three takeaways (from S8): it was a **network**, not one road; colonialism **restructured** mobility; modern states use the past **selectively** ("the past is mobilised, not neutrally remembered").
- Groupings: **BIMSTEC**, the Asian Trilateral Highway, **BCIM**, **BBIN**.

Earlier scholarship	Contemporary scholarship
One Silk Road, overland	**Many** Silk Roads, **land and sea**
Luxury goods; states and empires	Goods, **ideas, religions, people**; networks and mobility
National histories; fixed routes	**Connected, global** histories; changing networks
Texts only; China–Europe axis	**Interdisciplinary** (archaeology, GIS); **many centres**

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. How did trade and religion support each other in the maritime spread of Buddhism? (Sen)

Tansen Sen argues that Buddhism reached China by sea as well as by land, and that this spread was **closely tied to trade**. He rejects the label "maritime Silk Road", since silk was not the main cargo and the label wrongly makes China the centre.

Merchants gave monks passage, funded monasteries and carried relics and texts; monasteries gave merchants lodging, trust and blessings. Offerings of the "seven jewels" created demand for pearls and coral (Xinru Liu). The Indian ship-owner Nandin, who carried Gunavarman and Sri Lankan nuns to China, shows this link. **But** the relationship was not always friendly: "Brahmin" merchants on Faxian's ship wanted to abandon him in a storm.

Following Zürcher, Sen shows that Southeast Asia was first only a **transit zone**; the first Buddhist inscription there was set up by a sea captain, Buddhagupta. Later **Srivijaya** (1,000 monks, according to Yijing) and **Sri Lanka** (relics and Tantric teachers like Vajrabodhi and Amoghavajra) became hubs, and knowledge flowed back to India with Atisa.

Limitation: he relies on Chinese sources and gives little voice to local people or women. Still, he shows that religion became part of trade itself.

SESSION 10

Religions in India: Encounters, Adaptations and Transregional Influences

T.N. Madan (ed.), *India's Religions*, Introduction · John Guy, "Tamil Merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist Diaspora in Early Southeast Asia" · H.P. Ray, "A 'Chinese' Pagoda at Nagapattinam" + Lecture 10. **The professor's model short answer comes from here.**

IN ONE LINE

Religion in India is plural, diverse inside, lived and mixed into society (Madan). When people travelled across the sea, religion travelled with them and changed on the way (Guy, Ray).

Part 1: How to think about religion in India (lecture + Madan) MUST KNOW

Religions born in India

Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism

+

Religions that came from outside

Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism (Parsis), Bahá'í

The study of religion has shifted from looking only at **doctrines** to seeing religion as a **social and historical** thing.

Plurality ≠ Pluralism

Plurality = a **fact**: many religions exist. **Pluralism** = a **value or practice**: communities **negotiate** living together, through accommodation, interaction, borrowing, competition and even conflict.

Key question: how do people live with religious difference?

e.g. A town with a temple, a mosque and a church has plurality; neighbours sharing festivals shows pluralism.

Every religion is diverse inside

No religion is one single thing. Each has schools, sects, rituals, regional versions and rival authorities. Boundaries exist but are **not fixed or uniform**.

e.g. Hinduism: Shaiva, Vaishnava, Shakta, bhakti. Islam: Sunni, Shia, Sufi. Sikhism: Khalsa and Sahajdhari.

Religion as lived experience

Religion is more than belief: **belief → practice → experience → social life** (food, worship, pilgrimage, death rites, festivals, family customs). Keep apart **religion as doctrine** (texts) and **religion as lived practice**.

e.g. Texts draw sharp lines, but Hindus and Muslims both visit Sufi shrines.

Religion and society are intertwined

Religion is tied to caste, community, family, gender, economy and politics.

e.g. A **temple** is also an economic institution, a centre of redistribution, a seat of power, an employer and a marker of identity.

Tradition is not static

Tradition → adaptation → innovation. Traditions reinterpret old practices, create new movements and meet other traditions.

e.g. Bhakti, the Kabir Panth, the Ramakrishna Mission, Ambedkar's turn to Buddhism.

The colonial lens hardened identities

Missionaries studied Indian religions through a **Judeo-Christian model** (one God, one book, clear membership), which **did not fit** India (many ideas of God, regional variety, overlapping identities). From **1871** the British **census** put everyone into fixed boxes.

e.g. Fluid identities became "Hindu **or** Muslim **or** Sikh". Only in the 20th century did scholars adopt a pluralist view.

Part 2: Madan's main points MUST KNOW

MADAN'S ARGUMENT

1. India has religious plurality at **two levels**: **between** religions and **within** each religion (sects and movements).
2. Calling Indian religions "tolerant and plural" and foreign ones "uniform and rigid" is **wholly misleading**: any religion with millions of followers across regions becomes internally plural (Islam and Christianity in India too).
3. **Dharma ≠ "religion"**: dharma means duty, moral and cosmic order, a whole way of life (law, family, society). In India religion traditionally **includes** the secular.
4. **Plurality is a fact; whether it produced pluralism is a separate question.** Traditional "pluralism" was often a **ranking**.

Census 1991: Hindus about 82%, Muslims about 12%, Christians 2.3%, Sikhs 2%, Buddhists 0.8%, Jains 0.4%. Minorities are regionally concentrated (Muslims in J&K, Sikhs in Punjab, Christians in the North-East hill states and Kerala).

Quick guide to each religion (Madan)

Hinduism: a "federation of faiths"

- No single founder, book or church
- **Vedas** (from c.1500 BCE): **shruti** ("heard", revealed) vs **smriti** ("remembered": law books, epics, Puranas)
- **Manusmriti**: *varna-ashrama-dharma*, duties by caste and stage of life
- **Epics and Puranas**: gods like Vishnu (avatars, e.g. Rama, Krishna), Shiva and the Goddess
- **Bhakti** (loving devotion) began in the **Tamil south** and spread north
- Great teachers: **Shankara** (non-dualism), **Ramanuja**, **Madhva**
- Many sects: Shaiva, Vaishnava, Shakta (Goddess); Tantra

Buddhism and Jainism

- **Buddhism**: four noble truths, the eightfold path; the **sangha** (monks); split into Theravada, **Mahayana** (Nagarjuna) and **Vajrayana** (Tantric); declined in India; revived by **Ambedkar's** mass conversion of Dalits (**1956**)
- **Jainism**: **Mahavira**; strict **ahimsa** (non-violence), so many Jains became **merchants**; Shvetambara and Digambara sects; ***anekantavada*** (truth has many sides)

Sikhism

- **Guru Nanak (1469–1539)**, from the **sant** tradition: devotion to God's name; rejected empty ritual and caste; a "third path" beyond Hinduism and Islam
- **Guru Gobind Singh** created the **Khalsa** (**1699**), with initiation and unshorn hair, making a separate identity
- Later: Ranjit Singh's kingdom; Singh Sabhas; the Bhindranwale period. Madan: the Khalsa form is **exclusivist**, not pluralist

Christianity

- By tradition, **St Thomas** came to Kerala in the 1st century (the **Syrian Christians**)
- The Portuguese in **Goa**: **Francis Xavier** (1542), the Inquisition; Jesuits at **Akbar's** court; **de Nobili** lived like a Brahmin sannyasi
- Protestant missions (Ziegenbalg); the Church of South India (1947) and of North India (1970)

Islam

- Came first through **Arab traders** on the Kerala coast (the **Mapillas**, who kept local customs), then conquest (**Sind, 712**)
- Spread mostly **peacefully**, through **Sufis** and trade; the **ulama** (law scholars) vs the **Sufis** (mystics)
- Sunni and Shia; Sufi orders (Chishti); Kashmir's **Rishi** order mixed with local traditions
- Modern movements: **Deoband** (orthodox, 1867), **Aligarh** (modern education), the Barelwis, the Ahmadiyah

Lived mixing (examples to use)

- Sufi shrines visited by all faiths
- The Mapilla Muslims' local customs
- **Marriott**: ideas flow both ways between the "great" Sanskrit tradition and "little" village traditions

Did plurality produce pluralism? (Madan)

Who	Their idea (and its limit)
Rig Veda	"Truth is one, the wise call it by many names", but this applies **inside** Hinduism, not between religions
Traditional Hinduism	Each group has its own path (*svadharma*), but **not equal** merit: others were tolerated by being **ranked below** Hinduism
Vivekananda	Tolerance, but **Vedanta** is "the mother of all religions", i.e. the highest
Arya Samaj (Dayananda)	Only the Vedas are true; rejected Christianity and Islam: **exclusivist** (it anticipates Hindutva)
Gandhi	The most pluralist: "the world… **need not have** a single religion" (1913); all religions are **equally true and equally imperfect**; credited the Jain **anekantavada** for teaching him to see a Muslim "from his own standpoint"
Islam	"To you your religion, to me mine" (Quran). **Dara Shikoh** called Hinduism and Islam "twin brothers" (and was executed). Abul Kalam Azad: God of all creation

MADAN'S KEY CONCLUSION: TWO KINDS OF PLURALISM

Folk pluralism = ordinary people **naturally** living with difference: "social harmony is built on the basis of difference". **Intellectual or secular pluralism** = an **idea** promoted by elites and the state, e.g. *sarva dharma samabhava* ("equal respect for all religions"), which Madan says "does not go very far". There is a **gap** between the two.

Part 3: Religion on the move MUST KNOW

The bridge (lecture): "If religion is plural, lived, adaptive and socially embedded… how does it change when people move?"

Old view: "diffusion"

India → Southeast Asia, one way. India gives, others copy.

→

New view: "circulation"

India ↔ Sri Lanka ↔ Southeast Asia ↔ China. "Religion travelled because people travelled; what travelled was **transformed**."

Who carried religion?

- **Merchants** created the movement
- **Brahmins** brought rituals and royal kingship
- **Buddhist monks** brought monasteries and teaching
- **Kings** gave patronage and used religion politically
- **Artisans** made images

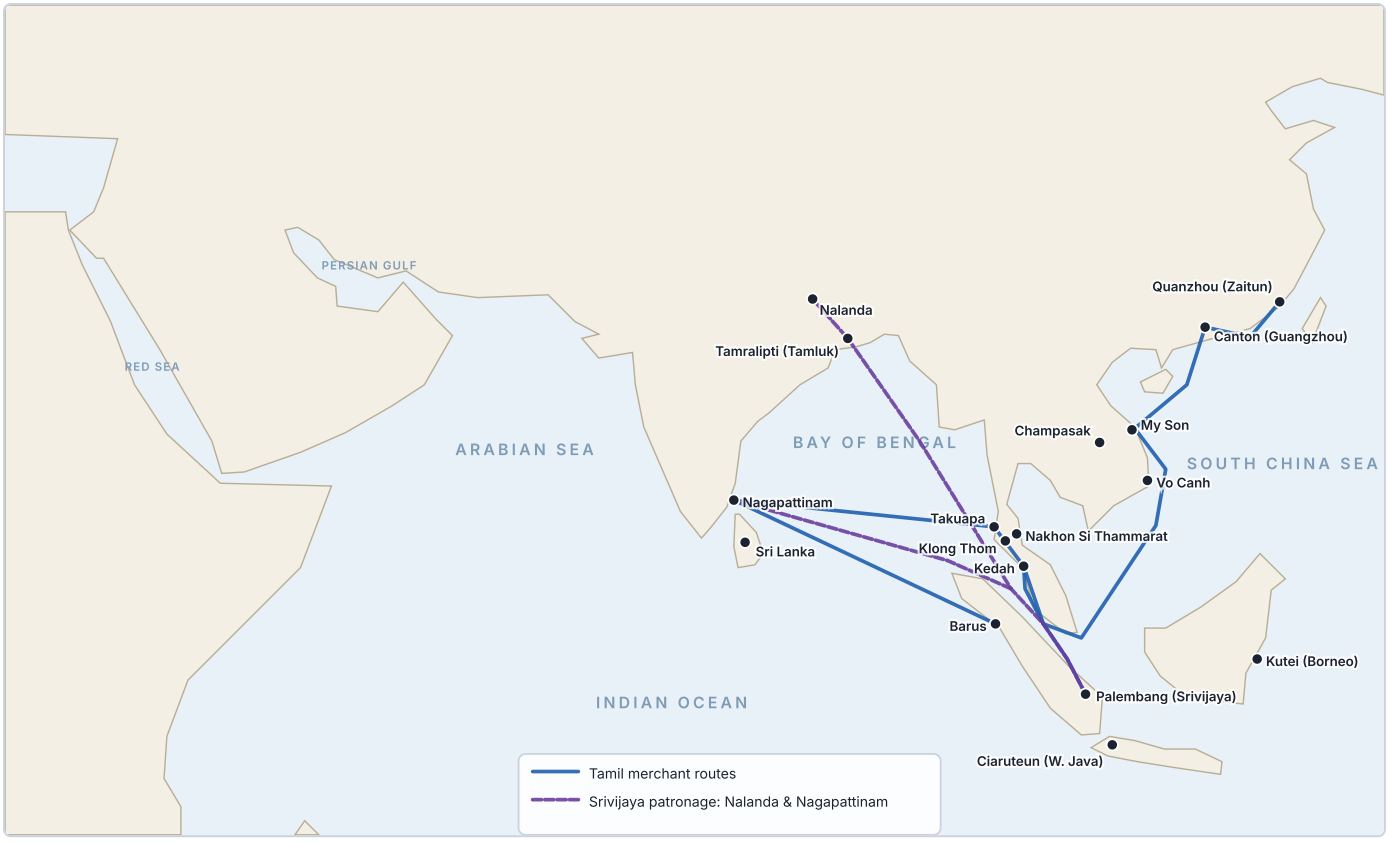
Merchant → settlement → community → temple. "Commercial mobility made religious mobility possible."

Encounter ≠ conversion

Traditions met and borrowed: shared words, shared holy places, new identities. They could **coexist, compete, borrow and adapt**.

e.g. Temples in Bali; the *Ramakien* (the Thai Ramayana); Mendut temple in Java.

The sea **connected**, not separated, South India, Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia and China.



Inscriptions and sacred sites of the Hindu–Buddhist maritime world (Guy; H.P. Ray). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

John Guy: Tamil merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist world

GUY'S ARGUMENT

Local Southeast Asian kings **invited** Brahmin priests and Buddhist monks for their own political benefit. But the **medium** was **merchant ships**, mostly **Tamil**. The inscriptions they left **map the trade routes**: coastal river sites linked to rich hinterlands.

Evidence	What it shows
Kutei, Borneo (late 4th c.)	Seven Sanskrit **yupa** (sacrificial post) inscriptions of King Mulavarman: the **earliest Indian-style inscriptions** in Southeast Asia; Brahmins performed Vedic sacrifice at court

Purnavarman, West Java (c.450)	Sanskrit inscription with **Vishnu's footprints**, which are **also the king's**: the first local king to identify himself with an Indian god. **Indian ideas + local politics = something new**
Klong Thom, Thailand (3rd–4th c.)	A goldsmith's touchstone with the **earliest Tamil inscription** in Southeast Asia, owned by "Perumpatan" (great goldsmith). Southeast Asia was the "**Land of Gold**" (Suvarnabhumi)
Takuapa, Thailand (9th c.)	Big Hindu statues and a Tamil inscription on a temple **tank** built by **merchant guilds** (the Manigramam)
Barus, Sumatra (1088)	A Tamil inscription of the **Ainnurruvar** guild: a fund for members; those who failed to pay lost trading rights
Kedah (5th c.)	The sea captain **Buddhagupta**'s Buddhist stone prays for a safe voyage
Guangzhou (750)	A Japanese monk saw **three monasteries of Indian Brahmins** and ships of Indians, Persians and Malays
Chola era (11th c.)	Chola missions to China (1015); Chola raids on **Srivijaya** (1026, 1068), rivals for the China trade
Quanzhou, China (1281)	A **Tamil–Chinese** inscription for a **Shiva temple**; its pillars were later reused in a Chinese Buddhist temple (Kaiyuan), carved by Chinese masons under a Tamil architect: "cultural syncretism"

Guy: Brahmanical ritual was linked to **kingship**, while Buddhism was more linked to **commerce**.

H.P. Ray: Nagapattinam, one port, many religions

RAY'S ARGUMENT

Indian sea history is usually told as trade driven by **Western demand**, ignoring coastal communities (historians assumed caste stopped Indians from sailing). Ray studies **maritime cultural landscapes**: coasts as places where religions met. The Tamil coast had **127 Buddhist sites**, which **challenges Cunningham's idea** that Buddhism died out in India around the 7th–8th century.

The Buddhist monastery (Cudamanivihara)

- Built at Nagapattinam by the **king of Srivijaya** (Sumatra), with villages granted by the **Chola kings** Rajaraja I and Rajendra I (the **Leyden copper plates**, c.1005)
- Burmese monks visited (1467)
- The Dutch called its tower the "**Chinese Pagoda**"; it was demolished by Jesuits in **1867**
- **350 Buddha bronzes** found (and more at Sellur in 2004)

Buddhism mixed with Hinduism

- Some Buddha statues were carried in **festival processions like Hindu gods**, with titles similar to Shiva's and Vishnu's
- One image was paid for by a guild official of "the merchants of the **eighteen countries**"
- Schalk: one form of Buddhism there was so close to Shaivism it was hard to tell apart

A multi-religious coast

A **Shiva temple** at Nagapattinam got jewels from **Srivijaya** and gold coins from **China**; later a **Sufi dargah** (Nagore) and a **church** (Velankanni); inland, Jain inscriptions and an 8th-century mosque.

e.g. Not "first Buddhism, then Hinduism", but **many religions side by side**.

Merchant guilds and Tamil inscriptions

Guilds (**Ainurruvar, Manigramam, Nanadesi**) had private armies and funded temples. **Eight** Tamil inscriptions are known from Burma to Sumatra and China. Ray also doubts the famous **Chola naval raid**, which rests on **one boastful inscription** (source criticism, S2).

The direction also reversed

Religion did not only flow **out** of India: Srivijaya funded Nagapattinam and Nalanda (King **Balaputradeva** built a monastery at Nalanda; the Pala king **Devapala** granted villages); Chinese donors gave to Tamil temples. India was a **node** in a network, not just a source.

Atisa: knowledge on a merchant ship

Atisa (982–1054) went from Bengal to Sumatra **on a merchant ship** to study, then to Vikramashila and Tibet. The same ship carried goods **and** religious knowledge.

THE LECTURE'S OVERARCHING ARGUMENT (MEMORISE)

Premodern religion was **mobile, networked, adaptive, plural and reciprocal**. Indian religions became important across Asia **not because they stayed the same, but because they could be carried, translated, appropriated and reinterpreted** in new places. **Madan** → religion is social and plural · **Guy** → it travelled through merchant networks · **Ray** → it created multi-religious landscapes.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS: THE PROFESSOR'S SHORT ANSWER (10 MARKS)

Q. Distinguish religion as doctrine from religion as lived practice in India.

The lecture and Madan argue that religion is more than belief: it moves from **belief → practice → experience → social life**. So historians must separate doctrine from lived religion.

Doctrine means the official teachings in sacred texts and from religious authorities: the Vedas and Manusmriti, the Quran and sharia (upheld by the ulama), or the Sikh Khalsa code. Doctrine tends to draw **clear boundaries** between religions.

Lived religion is what people actually do: food rules, festivals, pilgrimage, local saints. In practice boundaries are **porous**. Hindus and Muslims visit the same Sufi shrines, the Mapilla Muslims of Kerala kept local customs, and Madan calls this everyday mixing "folk pluralism". Religion is also embedded in society: a temple is an economic and social institution.

The difference matters. The colonial census (from 1871), using a text-based Judeo-Christian model, put people into fixed boxes and **hardened identities**. Studying lived religion shows that Indian religions were plural and changing, as at Nagapattinam, where Buddha images were carried in processions like Hindu gods.

SESSION 11

History of the Indian Ocean as a Connected Space

K.N. Chaudhuri, "The Unity and Disunity of Indian Ocean History... 622–1750", *Journal of World History* (1993) · Tirthankar Roy, *India in the World Economy*, ch. 4, "The Indian Ocean Trade, 1500–1800" (2012) + Lecture 11

IN ONE LINE

The Indian Ocean was connected but not the same everywhere: "unity in the large, disunity in the small" (Chaudhuri). Europeans entered and changed this working system, depended on Indian partners, and slowly turned trade into empire (Roy).

1. What does "connected space" mean? MUST KNOW

"Connection does not mean sameness; it means structured interaction across distance." The Indian Ocean linked **East Africa, the Middle East, South Asia, Southeast Asia and China**.

Five forms of connection

1. **Routes**: shaped by wind (monsoon), geography and custom
2. **Shared trade practices**: common norms of credit and exchange
3. **Migration**: people settled and carried skills and languages
4. **Religious networks**: belief and pilgrimage
5. **Political and military encounters**: war and diplomacy are **also** connection

Why it matters in world history

- One of the **oldest** arenas of exchange
- Long-distance trade **long before** European empires
- Goods, people, technology, languages and religion moved
- Central to Islam, India, Southeast Asia, China and East Africa
- **Decentres Europe**: Indian Ocean history is **not a "prelude"** to European expansion

Discussion question: was the ocean connected mainly by trade, or did trade depend on deeper links like **climate, religion and migration**? (Answer: both. The monsoon made trade possible, and religion and diasporas gave trust and credit.)



Indian Ocean c.1500–1800: Asian hubs, Portuguese bases, English presidencies (T. Roy). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

2. Chaudhuri: unity and disunity (622–1750) MUST KNOW

THE QUESTION

Fernand **Braudel** wrote the history of the **Mediterranean** (1949) as one sea with its societies, in terms of **space, time and structures**. Chaudhuri (author of *Trade and Civilisation in the Indian Ocean*, 1985, and *Asia Before Europe*, 1990) asks: **can we do the same for the Indian Ocean?** Sceptics said no: it has **no real unity**, no clear time frame, and Asia is "**too complex and diverse**", so they avoided the question.

UNITY "in the large": one ocean of trade (Arab ships sailed from Suez/Basra to China)
like Braudel's Mediterranean

ISLAM	SANSKRITIC INDIA	SOUTHEAST ASIA	CONFUCIAN CHINA
Middle East	South Asia	islands & mainland	East Asia
bread / wheat	wheat + rice	rice / fish	rice

DISUNITY "in the small": 4 different civilisations, foods, clothes, houses

Chaudhuri: similar at the big level, different at the small level.

Unity in the large vs similarity in the small

From maths (Wittgenstein): a **Möbius strip**, a cylinder and a twisted cylinder look the same if you cut out a small square of each ("alike in the small"), but their **overall shapes differ**. So matching small details don't prove a shared overall form, and differing details don't disprove it.

e.g. Word by word, the Rig Veda, the Quran and Confucian texts differ. But **Arab sailors could sail from Suez and Basra to China**, so at the level of **transcontinental trade** the ocean had real unity.

Why so few Asia-to-Asia comparisons?

In the past, Asian writers were curious about their neighbours. In the **19th century**, with Europe's power, Asian historians began comparing themselves **with Europe** (feudalism, capitalism). Their outlook turned from **latitudinal** (Asia ↔ Asia) to **longitudinal** (Asia ↔ Europe).

The time problem: Arasaratnam's critique

S. Arasaratnam said Chaudhuri proved **geographic** unity but not **chronological** unity for "750–1750". Chaudhuri replied that his period starts at **622** (the rise of Islam), not 750. The deeper point: **unity of space and unity of time may not match**. South Asian periods don't fit an ocean timeline; Islamic historians see a time unity but deny that "Asia" is a unit.

His theory (in short)

History is an interaction of **six domains**: real and perceived **space**, real and perceived **time**, real and perceived **structures**, plus a 7th, the "**logical space**". He mixes **four strands**: Braudel, **structuralism**, **semiotics** (study of signs) and **set theory** (maths). Critics called him a "latter-day Dr Faustus" drawing randomly on everything.

Chaudhuri's four conclusions

Conclusion	In simple words
1. **Invariance**	The "**ground floor**" of daily life (food, clothes, houses, religious principles, technology) stayed **basically the same** while varying within limits. **e.g.** Stomach-lining cells are replaced every few days, but the stomach keeps the same function.
2. **Four civilisations**	The ocean's unity is the sum of **Islam, Sanskritic India, Southeast Asia and Confucian China**. Set theory helps mark their boundaries (one person can belong to several sets, e.g. Muslim and Javanese).
3. **Totality**	Politics, society, economy and art form one whole; but each **action** is a simple yes/no choice (to act or not).
4. **"Perpetual memory"**	Societies copy their structures over time, like **DNA**. **e.g.** Dali's melting watches (*The Persistence of Memory*): even if the watch melts, if the dial and hands survive you can still read the time.

The "ground floor" of daily life (good examples) MUST KNOW

Food

- Every society separates "**food**" from "**non-food**", but what counts differs; there are also famine food, festive food and sacred food
- Two zones: **bread (wheat) vs rice**. To be invited to eat = to eat bread or rice. Middle Easterners ate both; rice-eaters rejected bread. **Dairy** disappears in Southeast Asia and China
- Dishes in the Quran and old Javanese inscriptions are still cooked today (**invariance**)
- Change: New World crops (maize, potatoes, tomatoes, **chilli**); **spicy-hot food may date only from the 16th-c. chilli** (before, black pepper gave the heat)

Clothing and housing

- Clothes match social identity almost exactly (tiny differences show gender and status). Unsewn, semi-sewn and fully sewn garments
- The white unsewn ***ihram*** of Muslim hajj pilgrims has the **same ritual meaning** as a **Brahmin's** unstitched worship dress (different form, same structure)
- **A house is a 3-D projection of the human body** and reflects power in the family and society

Dry zone vs wet zone

Dry (west and north): brick or stone houses, grain farming, fortified villages, a tendency to **political fragmentation**.

Wet (east and south): bamboo and wooden houses, sloping roofs, coconut, **rice fields and fish ponds**. Fragile irrigation gave rulers great power to **coerce**.

Nomads and farmers

Farmers needed animals (camels, oxen, buffalo) often bred by **nomads**. Nomads needed grain and cloth, and could take them as **tribute** by force; they also protected caravans. A two-way "symbiosis", with a constant threat of **nomad conquest**.

618 / 622	Tang China founded / Islam founded: the starting points. Four big expansions: **Islam, China, Turko-Mongol nomads, Europe**
Abbasid & Song	Abbasid control from the Mediterranean to the Indian Ocean; Song China's cities grow
12th–14th c.	Turko-Mongol conquests, famines, the **Black Death** (c.1345–49): instability
15th–17th c.	New big empires: **Ming, Ottomans, Safavids, Mughals** (absorbing the nomads)
1757	**Plassey**: the symbolic end of the cycle; European domination begins

Time: rare events explain more

The fewer times something happens, the more it explains.

e.g. The founding of Islam happened once but changed history; the thousands of meals you eat explain almost nothing.

Unity is partly in the historian's mind

Using **Foucault** and **Gödel** (logic always has contradictions), Chaudhuri says the unity of the Indian Ocean or of 622–1750 is a **mental construct**: historians **create** the unit that fits their question. "**Asia is the contradiction of Europe**" ("Asia" makes sense only against "Europe"). Even "Hindu" as a name came through contact with Muslims.

Skip: the maths details (Cantor, Dedekind, transfinite numbers). Just write "he used structuralism, semiotics and set theory".

3. Roy: Indian Ocean trade, 1500–1800 MUST KNOW

ROY'S ARGUMENT

Indo-European trade built a **new economic order**: it created new consumer markets in Europe, shaped world money markets (**silver**), pushed Europeans to **colonise** in the 18th century, and moved **technology both ways**. There was so much two-way traffic that it was **not** simply "Europe influencing India" or India being "absorbed" into a European world economy (contrast Wallerstein, S3).

Before 1500
Busy Asian trade; India in the middle of the "great arc"

→

1498 →
Portuguese: force and passes, but only partial control

→

1600 →
English (EIC) and Dutch (VOC) companies

→

c.1640–1690
Madras, Bombay, Calcutta

→

1757–1765
Plassey, Buxar: trade becomes **empire**

(a) The Indian Ocean in 1500: a crowded world

India in the middle of the "great arc"

- No single merchant group covered the whole arc. After **1400**, direct West Asia–China trade declined, so **Indian ports grew** as stops to change ships.
- Ports were **transit points, markets and production centres**.
- **Exports**: textiles (silk, muslin), rice, sugar, cotton, indigo. **Imports**: gold, silver, **horses**, and spices for re-export.
- **Route to Europe**: Cambay or Calicut → Aden or Hormuz → Suez or Basra → caravans to Cairo or Aleppo → **Venetian** merchants.

Merchant groups and ports

- **Gujarati Muslims** (Cambay), **Mapillas** (Malabar), **Chulias** and **Telugu Chettis** (Coromandel), Bengalis and Oriyas; each linked to shipbuilding
- **No port was tied to a big inland empire** (e.g. Calicut's small Samudri king)
- New hubs: **Masulipatnam** (Golkonda) and **Surat** (Mughal from 1576)

e.g. Lecture: "Europeans entered a **crowded and functioning** commercial world, not an empty stage."

(b) The Portuguese: violent but limited

- **1415** — Portugal (a **poor** country with good sailors) captures **Ceuta** in Africa, then moves down the African coast step by step
- **1480s** — **Bartholomew Diaz** rounds the Cape of Good Hope
- **1498** — **Vasco da Gama** reaches **Calicut**, guided by a **Gujarati pilot**; trade fails, but he brings back **navigation knowledge**
- **1502–03** — Second voyage: treaties, but also the **bombardment of Calicut** and a **massacre** of pilgrims on a ship to Mecca
- **1503 →** — **Albuquerque** seeks territory: **Goa, Malacca, Hormuz**, a victory at **Diu**. A Crown monopoly (the Casa da India); ships had to buy **passes (*cartaz*)** and pay customs
- **after 1640** — **Decline**: only a poor Goa was left

Why so violent?

To push **Muslim merchants** out of the spice trade, plus a **crusading** spirit. It worked at first: pepper prices in Europe stabilised and profits were huge (much trade went on via **Antwerp**).

vs

Why did it fail? (debate)

Steensgaard: it was "**redistributive**", living off others' profits (protection money) rather than making its own. **Others**: **strong Asian states** (Mughals, Ottomans, Persians, Japan) resisted.

Bengal example: the adventurer **Sebastião Gonzales** seized **Sandwip** island from the Mughals (1607), betrayed his allies, and lost it to Arakan (1616). Lecture: the Portuguese **changed** the ocean but **never fully controlled** it.

(c) The East India Companies

Company	Origin
English EIC (1600)	London merchants (meeting 1599); royal charter with a **monopoly east of the Cape**
Dutch VOC (1602)	Many small companies merged; a **shipping cartel** with big armed ships; by 1630 it crushed Portuguese trade and pushed the English out of Indonesia, so the English focused on **India**
French (1664)	Formed by **Colbert**; secure in India only by about 1700 (Pondicherry)

What was new: organisation

- **Joint-stock** finance (many investors, shared risk)
- **Monopoly charters**
- **Forts, factories (trading stations), armed ships**
- A single company could send credible **diplomatic missions** to Indian courts

e.g. Roy's strongest point: **organisation mattered as much as military force**.

Three problems of the English Company

1. **Monopoly hard to enforce**: rival merchants and "interlopers"; bribes to local kings
2. **Private trade** by its own employees, which it could not control ("the more capable the officer, the bigger the conflict of interest")
3. **Embassies of limited use**: Mughal orders didn't reach the south; local governors blocked them; disputes over customs and the right to **mint coins**

What was traded: spices (early 1600s) → **Indian cotton textiles**, saltpetre, Chinese silk (1650–1750) → **Chinese tea** (late 1700s), paid for by Indian **opium**. Indian cloth also paid for spices in Indonesia and slaves in Africa. Trade ran on **American silver**, cheaper in Europe and in great demand in India. By mid-century the EIC had about **50%** of the textile market.

(d) Europeans depended on Indians

INDIAN AGENCY

Om Prakash: Europeans "had **no option but to operate within the given**" Asian system. Asian traders controlled **almost everything except the final sale and sea shipment**: overland, river and inter-regional trade.

Bankers

Turned imported silver into **coins**, lent money, changed currencies and sent money by **promissory notes** (hundis).

e.g. The **Jagatseths** of Bengal; bankers even supplied military intelligence.

Brokers

Took company **advances** and gave out cloth orders to many sub-contractors; knew the market and language. Relations mixed **dependence and distrust**.

e.g. **Kasi Viranna** (Madras); **Kola Venkadri**, jailed by the English for secret talks with Golkonda; **Amirchand**, who plotted against Siraj ud-Daula (1756) and was punished by Clive; **Ananda Ranga Pillai**'s diary describes the hard job.

"Contract" was new

Hindu and Islamic law dealt with **debt**, not sales contracts, so the word "contract" was probably brought by Europeans. Written contracts fixed quantity, price, quality and advances; they helped bookkeeping and carried **moral** force.

Coastal shipping and technology

Indian communities owned coastal boats (**dhows**, **dhonis**). Technology moved both ways: Europeans copied Indian **cloth printing**; India learned from European navigation (shipyards like **Narsapur Peta**; European-style anchors).

(e) Port towns: Madras, Bombay, Calcutta

From tenants to landlords

In Surat and Masulipatnam the English were only **tenants** sharing rights. In **Madras (c.1640), Bombay (c.1660) and Calcutta (c.1690)** they were **landlords** with their own laws, courts and forts. Indian merchants and artisans moved in for safety.

e.g. Founders like Francis Day, Aungier and Job Charnock clashed with London directors; local officers rebelled (Winter in Madras, 1665; Keigwin in Bombay, 1679), so town governors got the power to **make laws**.

Why they mattered (lecture)

New **political-commercial spaces**: more **independent** of inland powers, **ocean-facing**, with **commercial law** that attracted capital, and bases for growing company power. Roy calls them a **major turning point**.

e.g. Maratha raids in the 1740s made Calcutta a safe haven; its population doubled.

(f) From trade to empire

1707	**Aurangzeb dies**; the Mughal empire breaks into regional states
1740–60	Three **Carnatic wars**: English vs French (linked to European wars); the English win
1757–64	Bengal: a dispute over taxing Europeans → **Plassey (1757)**, **Buxar (1764)**; the EIC becomes ruler of Bengal (1765)
1772 / 1813	War debts → a loan from Parliament and closer control / end of the Company's trade **monopoly**

TRADE → EMPIRE (THE "BRIDGE POINT" OF THE LECTURE)

Trade did **not automatically** create empire, but it created the **conditions**: forts piled up power; companies **blurred trade and sovereignty** (merchant + state); **Mughal decline** opened space; port cities became **bases for conquest**. Violence mattered, but Europeans still **depended on Indian brokers, bankers and shipwrights**: empire grew through **entanglement**, not replacement. (And Asian trade before 1500 was not purely peaceful either.)

Discussion: if Europeans depended on Indians, what was new? Not better commerce, but **organisation** (joint-stock companies, charters), **armed** shipping and forts, and above all **port cities with their own law**, which, as the Mughals collapsed, became bases for conquest.

4. Chaudhuri vs Roy, and the limits of "connected space" MUST KNOW

Chaudhuri	Roy
Big-picture, **theoretical**	Factual, **economic**
Unity and disunity; civilisations	Merchants, companies, ports; institutional change
Very long term (622–1750)	1500–1800 transformation
Connection as **theory**	Connection as **commercial practice**

They are **complementary, not opposed**.

Strengths of the idea

Breaks **national** history boundaries; **decentres Europe**; shows **mobility and interdependence**.

but

Limits

May **flatten local differences**; focuses on **merchants** over labourers and peasants; may hide **coercion, slavery and inequality**; makes connection look smoother than it was.

"Connected for whom? On whose terms?"

CONCLUSION (LECTURE)

Unity did not mean sameness. Trade was central but **not the whole story** (ecology, religion, migration, empire). **European expansion transformed, but did not create, Indian Ocean connectivity.** It was "a connected, contested and constantly re-made world", significant "not because it erased difference, but because it connected different worlds in durable, unequal and transformative ways".

Chaudhuri's terms (lecture glossary)	
Longue durée	Long-term structures, slow change
Invariance	Deep continuity despite surface change
Structuralism	Search for underlying organising principles
Unity/disunity	Connected and different at the same time
Logical space	The mental field where meaning and classification work
Mapping	Projecting one structure onto another to compare

Roy's terms (lecture glossary)	
Littoral	Coastal trading zone
Joint-stock company	Capital pooled by shareholders who share risk
Monopoly charter	Exclusive trading rights from the Crown
Broker	Middleman between the company and local producers
Factory	A **trading station**, not an industrial factory

Isomorphism	Same structure in different forms (*ihram* ≅ Brahmin dress)
Temporal structure	Different time-scales explain differently
Civilisational identity	Big formations like Islam or Confucian China

Commercial law	Rules for contracts, property, trade
Port city sovereignty	Town control that let companies shape government
Indo-European trade	Trade linking Indian and European systems

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (ESSAY OUTLINE, 15 MARKS)

Q. "European expansion transformed, but did not create, Indian Ocean connectivity." Discuss.

Intro: "Connected space" means structured interaction across distance, not sameness. The Indian Ocean was connected long before 1500.

Before Europe: monsoon trade from Baghdad to Canton with India at the centre (Bernstein); monks on merchant ships (Sen); Tamil temples from Java to Quanzhou (Guy). Chaudhuri shows "unity in the large" across four civilisations from 622, with a shared ground floor of daily life.

Europeans arrive: the Portuguese (1498) used violence and the cartaz, but never fully controlled trade (Steensgaard vs strong Asian states). The EIC and VOC brought joint-stock organisation, but **depended on Indian bankers and brokers** such as Kasi Viranna and Amirchand (Roy).

Transformation: port towns (Madras, Bombay, Calcutta) with their own law; Mughal decline after 1707; Plassey and Buxar turned trade into **empire**.

But: connection was unequal (force, slavery, coerced weavers). "Connected for whom?"

Conclusion: Europe changed **who held power**, but the network itself was much older.

LAST

Night-Before Revision Sheet

Read this once tonight and once before the exam. One line per session, the names and dates for MCQs, and the questions most likely to come.

S	The one idea	Names + 1 example each
1	Societies use the past as **pattern → model → process**	**Hobsbawm** (1972) · Zapata · Warsaw = symbolic restoration
2	Find → check → interpret → explain; **compare** cases	**Droysen**'s 4 steps · **Lange** (CHA) · **Backerra** (diplomatic letters)
3	**Global** = connections; **regional** = inside. Use both	**Wallerstein** (core/periphery) · **Hall** (multiple globalizations) · da Gama at 3 scales
4	Orientalist → Colonial → Nationalist → Marxist → Cambridge / Subaltern	**Jones** 1784 · **Mill** 1818 · **Jayaswal** · **Kosambi** · **Guha** 1982 · **Said** 1978
6	Travel writing = evidence + opinion → **corroborate**	**Faxian**, **Xuanzang** (Harsha, Nalanda), **Yijing** · al-Shahrastani vs al-Biruni
7	Monsoon trade = **premodern globalisation**, India at the centre	**Bernstein** · Gujarat/Cambay · Malacca (84 languages) · Zheng He 1405–33
8	No single Silk Road; **city lens vs region lens**	**Hansen** (Chang'an, Sogdians) · **Bhattacharya** (Bengal, cotton, cowries) · BRI 2013
9	Buddhism went **by sea with merchants**; "maritime Silk Road" is misleading	**Tansen Sen** · transit zone · Srivijaya · Sri Lanka relics · Atisa
10	Religion is plural, lived, and **changes as it travels**	**Madan** (plurality ≠ pluralism) · **Guy** (Purnavarman) · **Ray** (Nagapattinam)
11	Unity in the large, disunity in the small; **trade → empire**	**Chaudhuri** (622–1750, 4 civilisations) · **Roy** (EIC, brokers, Madras/Bombay/Calcutta)

Dates worth remembering (MCQs + answers)

325 BC	Chandragupta date ("sheet anchor", Jones)
399–413	Faxian's journey
629–645	Xuanzang in India (met Harsha)
622	Rise of Islam (Chaudhuri's start)
750	Abbasids, Baghdad
878	Huang Chao massacre at Canton
c.450	Purnavarman's Vishnu footprint (Java)
1281	Tamil–Chinese Shiva temple inscription, Quanzhou
1405–33	Zheng He's voyages
1498	Vasco da Gama at Calicut
1511	Portuguese take Malacca
1600 / 1602	English EIC / Dutch VOC
1707	Aurangzeb dies; Mughal breakup
1757 / 1764	Plassey / Buxar
1784	Asiatic Society (William Jones)
1818	James Mill's *History of British India*
1871	Colonial census categories begin
1877	"Silk Road" named (Richthofen)
1972 / 1982	Hobsbawm's essay / Subaltern Studies
2013 / 2014	China's BRI / India's Act East

Most likely questions (prepare these)

SHORT ANSWERS (10 MARKS)

1. Doctrine vs lived religion (S10) **(model answer given in class)**
2. Pattern, model, process (S1)
3. Usefulness of foreign travellers; al-Shahrastani vs al-Biruni (S6)
4. Hansen vs Bhattacharya: "no single Silk Road" (S8)
5. Why "maritime Silk Road" is misleading; monks and merchants (S9)
6. Why India was central to Indian Ocean trade (S7)
7. Global vs regional history (S3)
8. Plurality vs pluralism (S10)

ESSAYS (15 MARKS)

1. Was Marxist "new history" an advance over colonial and nationalist history? (S4) **(model essay given in class)**
2. Europe transformed but did not create Indian Ocean connectivity (S7 + S9 + S10 + S11)
3. "Religion travelled because people travelled" (S9 + S10)
4. "Unity in the large, disunity in the small": Chaudhuri and Roy (S11)

Essay shape: intro with a thesis → 3–4 paragraphs, each = one point + scholar + example → one "but" paragraph → conclusion linking to "India was connected long before Europe".

5 SENTENCES YOU CAN DROP INTO ALMOST ANY ANSWER

1. "The past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness" (Hobsbawm): every age rewrites it for its own needs.
2. Every source is both evidence and interpretation, so historians must corroborate.
3. The scale we choose (city, region, ocean, globe) decides what we see.
4. Asia was connected long before 1500; Europe transformed but did not create that world.
5. Religion travelled because people travelled, and it was translated, not simply copied.